

Films of 2024



Rules: 1) Almost always be (primarily) English language, 2) Must be a non-documentary feature. Sorry, otherwise this list gets another 20+ films added and I do not have that much time. 3) US Theatrical(-ish) release in 2024 (some of these films might have IMDb years for earlier due to film festival releases, or for example a 2023 Australian release before a 2024 US release). This year US theatrical-ish release has been pushed to its limits; some films with early 2024 releases – but a 2023 film festival showing – that were 2023 award eligible, are counted as 2023 and therefore are not included in this list. With the rise of (direct-to-) streaming, multiple awards have a TV-or-Streaming Movie Category. When applicable these films are included as well.

Within a tier, I believe the films are roughly the same quality. Between tiers, I believe there is enough distinction to say a film is better than those in the lower tier. Although, that distinction is blurrier for films at the bottom of a tier and the films at the top of the previous tier.

Selection Criteria: 1) Oscar Nominated, 2) Golden Globe Nominated, 3) Independent Spirit Awards, 4) BAFTA, 5) GLAAD Awards, 6) Black Reel Awards (replacing NAACP Image), 7) AACTA Awards (Australian Oscars) 8) Sundance, 9) Guild Awards: SAG, DGA, PGA, ACE, and ASC, 10) AFI Top 10, 11) National Board of Review, 12) Critic's Choice Awards, 13) British Independent Film Awards (BIFA)), 14) Annie Awards, 15) My own idiosyncratic preferences, 16) Some heterogeneous-minimum Rotten Tomatoes score regardless if nominated. Note: These are not necessarily the ranking of a criterion's importance.

[A selection criterion is in brackets to give an idea of why the film was on my list; award nominations are given preference, but also my own idiosyncratic reasons for watching, when applicable. Films were on the list before awards seasons, but the nominations/awards reflect that these did end up being good films.]

Streaming service is up-to-date as of **July 3rd**; afterwards who knows. So watch them now. I only included without-ads services. I did not include 'free' streaming with a cable add-on (Starz, Showtime, etc). Many of these can be rented on streaming services, but the ability to rent was not included.

Tier 16: Dear God No

202. **Madame Web:** The film is even worse than you'd expect. Its 11% on Rotten Tomatoes might be generous. This is one of the worst movies ever made, especially as unlike some of the other contenders, this had a budget of nearly 80 million dollars. The script is god awful (even if there are two legit funny lines) and the bad lines are delivered with enough campiness for the movie to be so-bad-its-good. Two of the script writers also wrote *Morbius*. Isabela Merced (*Rosaline*) and Sydney Sweeney's characters are not developed at all (Sony executives just assumed we'd want to watch them carry a future movie?). The opening Amazon sequence is so bad, even if the movie was tolerable, the film couldn't be salvaged. Most of the villains lines were re-added with ADR and do not match his mouth at all. The direction itself is off, as there are random dutch angles every other scene. It appears at every opportunity, Sony executives mad the conscious decision to make the film worse as they were so desperate to manufacture a monkey-making hit. [Golden Raspberry – Worst Picture], *Netflix*.
201. **Founders Day:** It seems every year a few low-budget horror films sneak onto the list that have no business being watched. This is one of them. The film is suppose to be a slasher and political satire. Except, the film is never scary, nor is it ever campy. Its political satire is cheap, lazy, and does not work. The no-name young actresses aren't good (and if we are sticking with 80s cliches, they aren't attractive enough either). The entire film does not work. William Russ (*Boy Meets World*) is the only bright spot. Avoid. [My Yearly Mistake]

Tier 15: Avoid

200. **Ganymede:** A horror that lacks scares and is at least fifteen-years late to the party. A 'horror' about a closeted teen in a religious family could be ripe for character development and scares. However most of the actors are no-names and can not act. Thankfully, David Koechner (*Anchorman*) shows up as a fundamentalist preacher and has a blast in the role. The sets are cheaply decorated, and most of the film does look cheap. This doesn't work as an LGBT film nor as a horror; avoid. [Decently-reviewed Horror]
199. **Out Come the Wolves:** For its genres the film lists Drama, Thriller, and Horror. It is none of these. The first forty-ish minutes are suppose to be a suspenseful character drama about a couple and her (male) best friend from childhood. Yet the neither the script nor actors deliver the tension needed. Once people go off hunting, the film goings off the rails completely; one even wonders if the scriptwriter has even ever gone hunting. There is not an iota of realism in the hunting sequences. The film is a giant miss and slog even at 90 minutes long. [Decently-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
198. **Apartment 7A:** A prequel to *Rosemary's Baby* that adds nothing to the franchise(?). The film follows nearly the same plot as the original, with the residents of the Bramford trying to birth the anti-Christ. Yet the audience already knows this from having seen one of the best films ever. The film adds little new backstory and the residents still use their power to improve the lives of those trying to birth the anti-Christ. One can only hope co-writer-director Natalie Erika James (*Relic*) took the film for the money or to get her future projects funded, as her first film established her a force in the horror genre and this film has no scares, no mood, no nothing. Julia Gardner (*The Royal Hotel*) is rather good and the only real bright spot in the film, with Dianne Wiest being the only other potential bright spot. Even if you are a fan of the original, this is not worth watching, unless you a bored one night and want a brain-dead watch. [Prequel], *Paramount+*.
197. **Scarygirl:** An Australian animated film that commits the cardinal sin of children's films: there is nothing for adults here. The plot is also far too bizarre for children: A human scientist is harvesting the 'power' of octopuses and the sun in attempts to recreate his daughter and bring her back from

the dead. The animation itself often looks cheap despite lots of colors. The voice acting is far too standard. There isn't much to write home about here. [Annie – Best Character Design Nominee], *Hulu*.

196. **Spellbound:** The film is a forced *Disney*-knockoff, right down to the hiring of Alan Menken (*The Little Mermaid*, *Beauty and the Beast*, *Aladdin*) for the score and songs. Yet the songs are not very good (Menken does melodies, not lyrics). The voice cast is a collection of A-listers but they aren't given much room to shine as the script is poor (Nathan Lane even voices a supporting character; again it is a forced *Disney*-knockoff). The animation quality does look good, especially items involving the clothes and grass. The morals in the film are good enough for children (the film has little for adults, but it does have something for them in the relationship of the parents). It is sad, that in an era where *Disney* can't do anything right, an obvious knock-off can't be better than the *Disney* films from this year. [Annie – Best Character Design Nominee], *Netflix*.
195. **Argyle:** I get that Apple is flush with cash, but there is no reason for this film to have cost the alleged 70–80 million dollars (Apple spent 200 million for the rights!). The VFX often look bad. The fight choreography is often poor. The cast itself is deep, so perhaps Apple paid a lot in actor salaries. Sam Rockwell, Bryan Cranston, and Catherine O'Hara have fun with their roles. What little John Cena we get is always enjoyable. Henry Cavill on the other hand took the paycheck. Dallas Bryce Howard is grating as Elly Conway. The film should never have been two-hours-and-twenty minutes long. Had it been cut down to closer to an hour forty it might have been a bit more enjoyable. There are too many 'twists' and 'turns' for a pseudo spy-parody (and a reminder that *Austin Powers* will never be topped). There is an 'ice skating' scene that perhaps if on shrooms is amazing, otherwise it is bizarre. The film is also the softest PG-13 rating ever, the kills resemble those in the Hays Code-era Hollywood film; instant death and no blood. Matthew Vaughn (*The Kingsman*) attempted to create another franchise and failed. [I Had to Know if it was as bad as the Reviews], *Apple TV+*.
194. **The Watchers:** The film is everything you'd expect from M. Night Shyamalan's daughter. The script is overly explanatory. The characters are not very deep, but the film thinks they are. The film tries to be a horror but is never scary. There is a twist you'll see coming. There is a natural ending, but the film continues for another twenty minutes, because said twist needs to occur. Dakota Fanning is decent, but nothing special and certainly not enough to elevate the film much. That Ishana Night Shyamalan was given 30 million to make an imitation of her father's films is sad. [Poorly-reviewed Horror], *HBO Max*.
193. **The Emu War:** A low-budget Australian satire, which does lean heavily into the absurdity of the premise; including emu puppets. Yet, there is not much of a plot and perhaps worst of all only about 30% of the bits lands. Meaning about 70% are just bad and groan-inducing. The film also never really achieves so-bad-its-good status either. Thankfully the film is 75 minutes long so the bad jokes are over quickly. [AACTA – Best Independent Film Nominee]

Tier 14: Not Good At All, But At Least One Thing To Make It Sorta Tolerable

192. **Before Dawn:** The film was nominated for Best Indie Film at the AACTA Awards. Yet, I can't help but wonder if the nomination was a result of making a WWI film on a budget of less than 6 million US dollars (the same budget as Oscars Best Picture winner *Anora*). As it often looks cheap, the trenches aren't very deep or fortified; multiple shots are at night with no stars in sight. The script itself is rather bad as it is episodic and the various supporting characters are always getting killed off. The actors are also nobodies who struggle with the poor dialogue (again that budget). Given the recent revival in WWI films, this is easily one of the worst (and cheapest). [AACTA – Best Independent Film Nominee]

191. **Here:** Except for a cinematic style choice that I believe works, the film is a flop. The ‘slice-of-life’ style doesn’t work when most all of the sequences are major life moments. That is not a slice of life. The choice to start with a bad *Tree of Life* sequence needed to be shot down. Everything dealing with the Native Americans and Benjamin Franklin needed to be cut. The de-aging technology used on Tom Hanks and others did look really good. Tom Hanks looked like he did in the early 80s in a few scenes. The airplane pilot family could have been used more. Also because the film focuses on the big life events, it makes it nearly impossible to find thru-lines besides people eventually die. One would have thought Robert Zemeckis could have handled the material better, instead he leaned into needless sentimentality. [Zemeckis and Hanks], *Netflix*.
190. **Close to You:** An Elliot Page passion-project, that serves as an example of maybe you shouldn’t make your pet project. Elliot Page essentially plays Elliot Page, in a movie about the trans experience which is about eight years too old. It offers nothing new to the genre, and relies on Elliot Page to carry the film. The direction from Dominic Savage isn’t great. The improvised dialogue often veers into face-palm territory (again the film needed to be made many years ago). Everything involving Hillary Baack’s character is annoying (and one wonders if that subplot was added because they realized there wasn’t enough material to make a feature-length film with the going-home plot). There are better movies about the trans experience and it is a shame Elliot Page wasted his time on this one. [BIFA – Best Lead Nominee], *Netflix*.
189. **Deer Camp ’86:** A low-budget horror-comedy that is rarely scary and rarely funny. The idea of the script is decent with themes about Native Americans and conservation, but it often heavy-handed. The group of hunters often feels like a dollar-store Broken Lizard, including an over-the-stop-but-not-funny fat man (no one takes home a deer you ran over, among other nonsensical items). A tighter script, with better actors, and this film could have been decent, instead of a boring chore. [A Horror]
188. **Godzilla x Kong: The New Empire:** I could honestly copy-and-paste my review from *Godzilla vs Kong*. As it is more of the same. The cast is solid, but their character development is eschewed for monsters fighting. This time I’ll at least list their names: Rebecca Hall, Brian Tyree Henry, and Dan Stevens. There are lots of monsters, they fight each other, and often fight each other at cool-looking and famous locations. [*Monsterverse* Franchise], *HBO Max*.
187. **Back to Black:** If I had a nickel for every musical biopic about a British singer that starts with them performing a song made famous by Frank Sinatra with their father on this list, I’d have two nickels. Which isn’t a lot. This Amy Winehouse biopic is uninspired and still manages to be two hours. The film is mainly interested in her relationship with Blake Fielder-Civil. Yet outside of a The Shangri-Las providing the music for a meet cute, the film never shows why she loved him. The relationship had its major ups and downs and the film didn’t really show much of them. In fact, the film seems more interested in showing her getting her various tattoos. The film also never gets into her creative process; most of the production of her two albums are glossed over. Leslie Manville is delightful as her grandmother, as to be expected. Overall the film feels like one that got the music rights first, and then haphazardly threw together a film second. [BIFA – Best Supporting Performance Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
186. **Monster Summer:** Directed by David Henrie (*Wizards of Waverly Place*) the film wants to be a throw-back to those 80s and 90s (pre-)teen adventure and “horror” films; a *Stranger Things*-lite. And yet it is never adventurous enough to be fun. While the references are too forced to be a nostalgia trip for adults. (I should mention, I’ve never been a fan of that subgenre of films.) The only enjoyable item is Mel Gibson plays the trope character of the loner-old-man-the-kids-are-scared-of and does it decently. It is never causes you bang your head against the wall, but it still doesn’t do much of anything to make it worth watching either. [Decently-reviewed Horror]

185. **Hell Hole:** I've been a fan of the Adams Family films (*Hellbender*, *Deeper You Dig*, *Where the Devil Roams*) as they been making low-budget indie horrors for a few years now. Sadly, this film is easily their worst. It lacks some of their beautifully composed shots. The film itself is more of a horror-comedy than a horror, and they are unable to pull off the comedy aspect of the film. Their daughters were also not in the film, but they did find Olivera Perunicic, who should be given a chance to break out in a future english-language film. [Well-reviewed Horror]
184. **Nightbitch:** An awkward mess of a film that never knows what it wants to be. The film is tonally inconsistent veers from comedy, to drama, to body horror and none of it works. The family-drama plot is far too basic. The spoken inner-monologues are dreadful. Amy Adams is decent, but the underlying film is so poor it can't be salvaged. The flaws are in writer-director Marielle Heller's (*Can You Ever Forgive Me?* and *A Beautiful Day in the Neighborhood*) adaptation of the source material (I assume, as inner monologues and such work better in books). Note: she didn't write the script for the two films listed in her parenthetical. Thankfully it is an hour-forty, as if it extended out to two hours it might have moved down a tier. [Golden Globes – Best Actress in a Comedy Nominee], *Hulu*.
183. **Time Cut:** Co-written by Michael Kennedy (*Freaky*, *It's a Wonderful Knife*), the film is his second straight disappointment and a promising start. The film doesn't make much use of its time-traveling premise (and in many ways is a vastly inferior *Totally Killer*). The setting of 2003 is limited to the clothing, a few songs played on CDs, and forced phrases of the era; it never really feels like 2003. It also is never scary, nor is it ever campy enough. Although it might seem like a good late-night watch, it isn't even that good, unless you only want background noise. [Decently-Reviewed Horror], *Netflix*.
182. **10 Lives:** An animated film that often looks cheap and relies too much on the audience liking cats and children. The voice cast is disappointing, with Bill Nighy really phoning it in as the literal cartoon villain of the film. Also it should be noted that bee populations have rebounded. There is almost nothing for adults to get out the film and its basic script. [Sundance]
181. **Winner:** The second film about Reality Winner in two years, and although this film takes a more holistic approach to her life, it is far inferior to *Reality* with Sydney Sweeney and 'written' and directed by Tina Satter. At every point in this film, one wishes they were watching the Sweeney film (there is a bit of irony that the script to *Reality* is the word-for-word transcript of her initial interrogation; sometimes real-life is the best character development). While this film tries to be a light-hearted comedy (Zach Galifianakis, Connie Britton, and Kathryn Newton have supporting roles) while also being a political film. It never really works. Emilia Jones (*CODA*) is decent, but again Sydney Sweeney played this exact role much better a year ago. (Also Emilia Jones seems to be squandering her post-*CODA* career by continuing to work with director Susanna Fogel (*Cat Person*). Dont watch *Winner*; watch *Reality*. [Had to Compare to *Reality*], *Hulu*.
180. **Horizon: An American Saga:** Usually with these two-part films I'll watch them back-to-back, however I saw the first film in theaters near its release date. The first part looks decent, but not great. There is an 'epic' sequence of a fight, but it rarely looks or feels cinematic. The editing and pacing of this sequence does not work. A stirring sequence would have give the film the energy needed to continue. The first part itself is trying to juggle about seven different plot lines—without cutting between them with any semblance of logic or consistency. The plot fails to add much new to the genre. If anything, it is trying to shoe-horn a revisionist western into conservative values. [Kevin Costner], *Netflix* and *HBO Max*.
179. **Joker: Folie à Deux:** I don't think the movie is as bad as everyone has said. Now, the countless musical numbers are awful and distracting (there are a looooot of them). Even if the numbers are meant to troll the audience, that is a bit audacious. The courtroom scenes are funny with Joaquin Phoenix having an absolute ball. And there could have been a really good film about the criminal

justice system. Sadly it mainly misses the mark, and too many scenes are grating. Yet, there are some good parts which too often were overlooked. [Sequel], *HBO Max*.

178. **Streets of Colour:** The easiest way of describing it is an Australian *Crash*. Everyone has their own problems in a rough-and-tumble suburb, but faith in your guardian angel will lead you through. The ending gets rather spiritual/religious (some of which had been hinted at, so it isn't exactly out of the blue) and it only fits the film in the sense that it is a melodrama which only wants to superficially tackle problems. It should be worth saying that Australia has been making of these style films in the last few years, and they are starting to get a tad tiring (unless I am missing some specific local flavor). [AACTA – Best Indie Film Nominee]
177. **Between the Temples:** By most accounts this modern *Harold and Maude* should rank higher as Jason Schwartzman and Carol Kane (*Taxi*) are both good, and a fair bit of the lines are genuinely funny, “there isn't a heaven or hell, only Upstate New York”, and yet all off good things are ruined by director Nathan Silver. Given the historic length of the list, I'll outsource part of the review, “Smash zooms, herky-jerky camera movement, extreme close-ups, whip pans, insert shots... Silver and his team throw everything they can at the wall to see what sticks. The problem is that all that style ends up distracting from the dialogue and characters, leaving the impression of a director with a lack of confidence in his screenplay. The nominal defense for the overabundance of style is that Silver is trying to evoke the style of films from the '60s and '70s, evidenced by the film's grain and color grading, as well as the soundtrack choices. While all of these elements contribute to the film's '70s feel, the combined effect of all of them together in such close proximity to each other is overstimulating in the extreme, ultimately alienating viewers by pushing them away from the characters, instead of pulling them in.” <https://nextbestpicture.com/between-the-temples/> [Independent Spirit – Best Supporting Performance Nominee], *Netflix*.
176. **Firebrand:** The rare Henry VIII biopic that focuses on his final wife: Katherine Parr (technically the film is more about her than Henry). Alicia Vikander (*Ex Machina*) is one of the two good things about the film. She does a good job creating something out of nothing with the character as the script rarely is interested in developing characters. The other nice thing are the costumes (really the production values are quite nice). Jude Law is okay as an old and dying Henry (again, not a Henry we see much on screen). Although the film takes some historic liberties those are mainly forgiven, but what is not forgiven is the lack of character development. [BIFA – Best Costumes Nominee], *Hulu*.
175. **Trap:** M. Night Shyamalan has made yet another frustrating film. The rough premise is decent, Josh Hartnett (*Oppenheimer*) does a fair bit of lifting, and then without fail it goes off the rails in the third act (and not even because a wild twist!). You'll never actively hate yourself watching this, and as mindless entertainment Hartnett makes it serviceable. But this is another middling entry in late-career Shyamalan who has used up any goodwill from *The Visit* and *Split*. Yet, the films keep making massive profits, so he keeps making them. [Shyamalan], *Hulu* and *HBO Max*.
174. **Love Lies Bleeding:** Co-written and directed by Rose Glass (*Saint Maud*), the film is a disappointment. The goodwill from an interesting first feature (albeit with flaws) should be gone after this film. The writing is unfocused and the film ends up as this odd mishmash of various drama genres. The hair and make-up is often not good (a few critics will galaxy brain themselves into having the hair and make up be off-putting was the point and is therefore great). Kristen Stewart is good, but the character is not developed enough to allow her to shine. The same can be said about the other characters as well. [BAFTA – Outstanding British Film Nominee], *HBO Max*.
173. **Sting:** A 'horror' that relies on the audience being afraid of spiders. As if you are not afraid of spiders, there are not make scares. It also does not help that the film is entirely predictable and at times a bad family melodrama. Alyla Browne is the only real bright spot, and this is a breakout

year for her (as we'll see her a few more times on this list) and she is solidifying herself as one of the best kid/teen actresses right now. The film also annoys me as one of the characters (in an NYC apartment) saying, 'I am the building supervisor' something no one actually says, they would say 'super'. This film does not even rise to being worth a late-night watch. [Decently-Reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.

172. **Moana 2:** A sequel that was a pure cash grab by Disney. The songs are mediocre at best, and the main song, 'Beyond' is almost a word-for-word inferior version of 'How Far I'll Go'. Many of the songs are interrupted with dialogue. At times one wonders if the songwriters thought Auli'i Cravalho's voice could mask a bad song. The animation itself is often good with nice colors and great fine details on some of the outfits and the sand. It is abundantly clear the film was suppose to be a tv series and now will set the stage for Disney+ series that little kids will watch. One wonders if Disney has ran out of ideas. As even though both *Ralph Breaks the Internet* and *Frozen II* were not needed, those sequels had something to say and expand their universes and characters in meaningful ways. This sequel reuses roughly the same plot as before but with worse songs. [Golden Globes – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Disney+*.
171. **Wildcat:** Co-written and directed by Ethan Hawke (*Blaze*) it continues his string of middling biopics. Like his previous directorial effort the film is often slow and unfocused. Thankfully it continues his decent camera work and lighting. The idea of the film was to use scenes from Flannery O'Connor's life and splice them together with her stories, while all it achieves is making the audience want to read her stories; not adding much to her character (the film starts with a quote from her about writing not being an escape from the world, but a reflection of its truth). It was a worthwhile attempt, but it falls short. It helps that Maya Hawke is great as otherwise the film would have been a complete dud, as the film almost requires the audience to be somewhat familiar with O'Connor's work, even despite dramatizing some of the stories. [Ethan and Maya Hawke]
170. **Out of My Mind:** A Disney feel-good and inspirational film about a sixth-grade girl with cerebral palsy. I am not the target demographic for this film. There are a few too many plot contrivances (the tie-breaker is a classic one at least; the flight cancellation is lazy writing). As expected in these film the parents are played by respectable actors: Rosemarie DeWitt and Luke Kirby. Michael Chernus (*Severance*) is good as the teacher. Yet the characters are never developed outside of the lead. [Critic's Choice – Best TV Movie Nominee], *Disney+*.
169. **How to Make Gravy:** An Australian film, based on a popular Australian 'Christmas' song. Except if you are not aware of the song, the film is even worse (if you are going to make a film about songs – or singers – that are not famous in America, you Better make sure the film is actually good Man). The film also starts off horribly, letting the audience know the film will have cartoon villains. The 'unliked' family member arrives in a popped-collar and does not like the dog (the dog jumps on him and the voiceover by the kid mentions the dog had to be outside all day in a sad voice; this is a normal request! but instead the film really needs to make sure this character is bad). There are more of these in-your-face moments; the only thing that is not in-your-face is what gets the lead character put in jail (as again, his character needs to be completely sympathetic). Now, some of the moments almost land and Hugo Weaving is enjoyable in a supporting role. It does not work for an American audience. It does not work for an audience that wants characters. It only works for an audience that wants forced mawkishness. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee]
168. **Prom Dates:** A standard film about kids and prom, with an LGBT angle. Sadly, the only two good things about the film are Julia Lester and Antonia Gentry (*Time Cut*). The two leads are solid and work great together. Yet everyone else in the film is a let down. The character of Greg is the most grating, and in most movies the character of Luca would easily be the worst. Every supporting character is a poorly-written trope. Any chance of success the film could of had because of its leads

is left alone on the dance floor because the script and supporting character development is that poor. [WGA – Best Streaming Screenplay Nominee], *Hulu*.

167. **Fitting In:** It is a shame as there should be more films about being intersex, and yet this one fails. The film tries too hard to be educational about MRKH syndrome, instead of making the film about its characters. Speaking of characters the film hits far too many lazy writing tropes; the male gynecologist being the worst offender. It also committed the cardinal sin (to me) of wanting to be an uplifting/supportive messaging film instead of, again, focusing on developing characters (it should be noted that the type of film which makes this error are often this exact type of film). For example, there is a minor subplot about running track which adds nothing to the plot except as a strange device to force tension between characters (don't worry they'll make up because this is that type of film). [GLAAD – Best Limited Release Nominee]
166. **Force of Nature: The Dry 2:** Although technically a sequel to *The Dry*, it has little in common with the first film except for Eric Bana playing the same lead detective. My review of the first film was decent (ended up around 60th), because the cinematography was great (desert and the caves) while also adding an interesting take on Bana's cop character. Yet this film has a new cinematographer (and set in the jungle), and the background on Bana's character is that his mom nearly went missing in these same woods (oh and a serial killer used to be in those woods). The film doesn't work as a who-done-it, nor does it work as a character drama. The best parts of the first film were forgotten and the result is a routine cop drama. [AACTA – Best Actor Nominee], *Hulu*.
165. **Gladiator II:** The film is less of a sequel and more of a remake. The plot is nearly the exact same as the first film (and it should be noted that *Gladiator* is not *that* good of a film to begin with). The opening naval raid pales to the Germanic Battle in the first, and the naval raid seems like it re-purposed the CGI from *Napoleon* just a year ago. Paul Mescal is a great actor, but perhaps not an actor star. Pedro Pascal's voice is silly. Speaking of silly, sharks in the coliseum? Riding rinos? There are multiple bridges to far. The water battle in the coliseum could have been epic, but it was never given the grandeur it needed. Denzel Washington is fun, but even he can't overcome a deeply flawed script. [Oscars – Best Costumes Nominee], *Amazon Prime* and *Paramount+*.
164. **Humane:** The film is directed by Caitlin Cronenberg (*David Cronenberg's daughter*) and written by Michael Sparaga. The script has an interesting premise: society must reduce its population for reasons, so people can sign up to be 'enlisted'. Yet as the film progresses the enlistment-process has at least two 'fine print' reveals that are needed to advance the plot. Yet these are absurd and totally take the viewer out (if Caitlin Cronenberg had been a more experienced comedic director, perhaps the absurdity could have been leaned into). The script is filled with cliché and trope-y characters (the recovering addict son! who was also adopted!). Enrico Colantoni plays the only character that is developed and the film errs in making him the villain (and not the rich kids; nor is it funny enough to pull off the reversal). As all four rich kids are caricatures (the script is bad) and caricatures of too many different social issues. There was a good idea here, but it does not work as too many people involved were not experienced enough to guide it properly. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
163. **Terrifier 3:** Possibly the best film of the franchise, as it is the campiest. Art the Clown is allowed to have the most fun so far. Giving children 'presents' as Santa is hilarious. Though once again the film suffers from pacing issues (the film itself has no reason being over two hours), and there is rarely any frights, and once again the plot is iffy. At this point the franchise is delivering more of the same: great practical gory effects, some camp, and minimal plot. [Well-reviewed Horror]
162. **Venom: The Last Dance:** The final installment in the Tom Hardy *Venom* series continues to have the same highs and lows of the previous two films. This one is best when it is just Tom Hardy doing stuff, or when he is hanging out with the hippie family. Those parts are funny and wacky. Yet when the government/military/scientist get involved the film becomes a generic – and bad – comic book

movie where plot points are overly explained so the lowest common denominator audience member can still follow along. It isn't really a fitting end because the franchise wasn't allowed to fully embrace its Tom Hardy-driven irreverence. [Sequel], *Netflix*.

161. **The Six Triple Eight:** It seems every year a Tyler Perry film gets added to the list due to a nomination for something and without fail, while watching it, I end up wishing I was watching the Tyler Perry episode of *Atlanta*. Perry writes a script with awful dialogue and plot that has too much going on, ensuring the audience can follow along (the entire first forty minutes could have been scrapped). Kerry Washington (*Django Unchained*) is good, but at times goes over board. Ebony Obsidian would be considered a breakout star if the movie itself was better, but this should serve as a springboard for her career. Dean Norris (*Breaking Bad*) is fun as always as a racist general. Yet the film is too straight-forward in making sure the audience got the message, and tries a few too many times to force tears out of the audience. Tyler Perry gonna Tyler Perry. [Black Reel – Best Lead Performance Nominee], *Netflix*.
160. **Greedy People:** Outside of Joseph Gordon-Levitt going absolutely ham there isn't much to this comedy. The script does not have enough jokes, and some are only funny because of Gordon-Levitt's performance. The film also has no business being almost two hours, an hour forty would have tightened the film up and allowed for a more manic pace (the film plods along too slowly; complete with title cards for each section). There was the basis for something fun here, but it did not deliver. Which is sad as the rest of the cast is solid: Lily James, Tim Blake Nelson, Jim Gaffigan (as an Irish hitman!), and Simon Rex. But they are all let down by an unfunny script. [Well-reviewed Comedy]
159. **Drive-Away Dolls:** This list is going to heap a lot of praise on Margaret Qualley. But not in this film. She uses a baaaaad Texas/Southern accent that makes it nearly impossible to tolerate her lines. Had she spoke in a normal voice, this film could move up a tier, may two. The script itself is too sprawling and not enough of the jokes land. Ethan Coen's script is a let down, and incorporates the worse parts of the Coen Brothers Filmography (remember Brad Pitt's accent in *Burn After Reading*). And this is sad because the cast is great and they (sans Qualley's accent) appear to be having lots of fun; Geraldine Viswanathan, Beanie Feldstein, Colman Domingo, Bill Camp, and others. Even at 85 minutes the film has a lot of padding and although it can be good for an easy watch, it isn't one of the better fun watches of the year. [GLAAD – Best Wide Release Nominee], *Peacock*.

Tier 13: Indie Misses and Meh Studio Films

158. **Emilia Pérez:** The favorite film of the year of the most annoying person you know. The film semi-haphazardly bounces around from social issue to social issue without ever stopping to develop its characters. It also does not help that the film never fully realizes that Zoe Saldaña's character is the lead, instead shifting focus to the titular Emilia (while also not giving the characters quality interactions). It should be said that Saldaña's (*Infinitely Polar Bear*) performance is one of the few bright spots. The other two bright spots are the 'smells like' song/scene and the karaoke scene. Both look great are are the only real attempts at characterization. The praise for Selena Gomez seems to be more about supporting her taking more serious acting roles. The songs are almost all forgettable at best, and bad at their worst. The songs are tonally inconsistent and also add to the film not knowing what it is; it isn't a good musical, it isn't funny enough to be a campy comedy, it isn't written well enough to a quality drama. Instead it is this mess of a film that society ends up says nice things about so as to not stir the pot. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Netflix*.
157. **The Feeling That the Time For Doing Something Has Passed:** Each year I outsource one review to someone else. And this year's review will be brought to you by Amy Nicholson (who makes frequent appearances on KPCC's FilmWeek). Her words will be in quotes. The main issue with the film from writer-director-actor-editor Joanna Arnow is her script about a sexual submissive,

never seems to understand what it is like to be a submissive, “But from the snapshots we see, these encounters seem mostly humiliating and joyless. When obeying an order...she just looks bored.” This is a character who has been in submissive relationships for nine years and actively seeks them out! Though perhaps the most annoying feature of the film, “Arnow films her own nude body with the kind of frankness that is called brave because she wants to be more confrontational than arousing. She’s so visible that it takes a beat to remember that someone can be physically exposed and emotionally opaque.” As this is another film, where the filmmaker wants us to feel sympathetic for this socially inept person, without realizing the main character is the bad guy in the story, “Ultimately, the film reveals that everyone around Ann seems to be having more fun. Ann knows happiness is out there. But to take off the pig nose and admit she wants it? That’s just too vulnerable.” <https://www.nytimes.com/2024/04/25/movies/the-feeling-that-the-time-for-doing-something-has-passed-review.html> [Independent Spirit – Best First Screenplay Nominee], *Hulu*.

156. **Birdeater:** Admittedly this film should rank a little higher (not that much though), however the sound mixing is awful. The music is too loud compared to the dialogue. The dialogue is often muffled, and mixed into the rear speakers too much. The sound design is so bad it essentially took me out of the film. The film itself takes too many directorial flourishes (some of these work, but too many detract). Some detract due to a weak script that has big ideas yet rarely lands them (and lasts for almost two hours). There was something good here, but the awful sound design ruined the movie for me before the film ever gets going. [AACTA – Best Independent Film]
155. **Runt:** Every year it seems the AACTA Awards nominates a feel-good family picture. And every year I still watch it for some reason. This is a standard feel-good family film. There are two(!) cartoon villains (each aptly named Fergus Fink and Mr. Robert-Barren); at least they tried to have fun with the premise. But a little girl and her stray dog overcoming problems is never going to be my cup of tea. It is never bad-bad, but some of the bits do become grating (partially because I dislike the genre). [AACTA – Best Film Nominee]
154. **Rez Ball:** The film is 90-percent a re-hash of all the scrappy-team sports movies, and why it ranks low. Yet the other 10-percent is a new focus on the Native American characters, which allows the film to not be run-of-the-mill. Writer-director Sydney Freeland (*Drunktown’s Finest*) continues make decent movies about the Native American experience. The landscapes look beautiful. Some of the moments are touching. Yet, for the most part, it is all stuff you’ve seen before. One wishes the characters were more developed and that it strayed from the standard procedure, as it could have been a much more impactful film if it did. [Black Reel – Best Cinematography Nominee], *Netflix*.
153. **Bird:** This film should rank perhaps two tiers higher. However director Andrea Arnold (*American Honey*) made a post-production choice that ruined the movie for me and violates one of my commandments. The edges of the screen are purposely ‘distorted’ to make it look like a mis-threaded film in a projector, with ‘damage’ randomly added to the sides and corners of the screen. It is such a lazy way of making the film ‘real’ and ‘gritty’; and the movie does a good job of being real already! So because Andrea Arnold made such a dumb choice the film is all the way down here because when directors do something stupid they deserve to be punished. And it is sad because both Barry Keoghan and Franz Rogowski are good in supporting roles. The movie has some decent and new items to add to the coming-of-age genre, but again director Andrea Arnold could not get out of her own way. [BAFTA – Outstanding British Film Nominee]
152. **Christmess:** If I had a nickel for every Australian film set at Christmas about a father with a drinking problem on this list, I’d have two nickels. This is a slight improvement over *How to Make Gravy* as it is not as mawkish. Yet, it still adds almost nothing new to extremely crowded recovering-alcoholics genre. Most everything in this movie you’ve seen before; except for the lead trying to be

a mall Santa. The isn't tropey, but rather it isn't original. The performances were solid, but once again there is nothing you haven't seen before. [AACTA – Best Indie Film Nominee]

151. **Last Straw:** The film has a decent premise, and its non-linear structure elevates the film. Except the plot is filled with holes and poor character decisions. The decisions are at times mind-numbingly stupid: text a friend for help instead of calling 911 being the worst offender that essentially takes you out of the movie entirely. There are too many lazy criticisms of the female lead being unlikeable, the issue is the nonsensical decisions and plot holes (detailing more of the plot holes involve spoilers). The bones for a tight horror/thriller are here but are thrown out the window with too many plot holes. [Well-reviewed Horror]
150. **Blink Twice:** The film starts off with a trigger warning that spoils/ruins the entire film. There is no longer any suspense about what bad things will happen on the island. Whether films should have a trigger warning is a separate issue, the primary issue here is that a deliberate 'artistic' choice was made to spoil most of the film. And since I am in charge of the list, I can demote the film a tier. Forgetting are forced-spoilers, the film primary ends up being yet another *Get Out*-ripoff. Except this film really spells out the message long the way for the viewer, and has a few plot holes. Channing Tatum is the best part of the film as he is great in his role. Simon Rex (*Red Rocket*) continues his great year of character roles (even if the movies he is in aren't very good). The main actresses are solid: Naomi Ackie, Alia Shawkat, and Adria Arjona. Also, as wrong as it sounds, if these are rich and powerful men, they couldn't get hotter women to party with? (Which actually could have been an interesting plot point and character development, but the film was only interested in surface-level social commentary). The debut from writer-director Zoë Kravitz is a let down. A generic and mediocre horror/thriller can be enjoyable, but a mediocre (forced) social-commentary horror/thriller quickly becomes grating. [Black Reel – Outstanding Independent Film Nominee]
149. **Frankie Freako:** A no-budget film, that if you consume a fair bit of alcohol or shrooms before hand becomes stupid fun. It is a spoof on the various 80s puppet 'horror' films such as *Gremlins*, which are not my jam to begin with. The film is directed by Steven Kostanski (*Psycho Goreman*), however inline with the films it is parodying, the film stays at PG/PG-13 rating, and so it never fully embraces the zany fun that *Goreman* tapped into (*Goreman* is one of my favorite low-budget horror-comedies). Perhaps the worst part is that Conor Sweeney is not good enough in the leading role (he comes off as a no-budget Colin Jost; there is an argument to remake this with Jost and ScarJo and Che). Shabadoo! [Well-reviewed Horror]
148. **Hanky Panky:** A no-budget film, that if you consume a fair bit of alcohol or shrooms before hand becomes stupid fun. A group of people meet at a cabin in the woods; there is a talking hanky, and an evil talking hat. It is stupid and bizarre, yet it is so out there (and the film itself knows it) that the film mainly works. There could be more jokes crammed in. The pace could be a little faster. But for a movie made by friends on a camping trip in Utah, it is far more enjoyable than one might initial expect. There is a character who's main form of development is him drinking a Busch Light every minute, so enjoy the stupid fun of this comedy-horror (otherwise if you also haven been drinking multiple Busch Lights, you may find this dumb and awful). [Well-reviewed Horror]
147. **Arcadian:** For full disclosure, while watching this film the Luka-AD trade broke and that was a little distracting. However the news also broke when Nic Cage's character loses a bunch of screen time. Did I lose interest because the film got worse, or because the holy-cow breaking news? The film is a brisk 90 minutes, any longer and it would have been distracting. The creatures are something; neither good nor bad, but interesting (especially on a budget). Yet what is more interesting would have been Nic Cage fighting them. The plot gets iffy (the other farm ends up being more of a collective? but there a hierarchy? yet the farm hands take matters into their own hands?) There are interesting family dynamics but I don't think they come thru as well as they should (as once again, Nic Cage's character lacks screen time in the second half). [Nic Cage], *Hulu*.

146. **Mufasa: The Lion King:** The film is a cash grab, and the writing is awful. Yet director Barry Jenkins (*Moonlight*) is able to make the film tolerable. I counted at least six references to the original Mufasa death scene in the 1994 movie. ‘Circle of Life’ was uttered multiple times, same with ‘He Lives in You’. In too many ways this is not an original film at all. The Scar origin story is rather weak (Scar is clearly the campy gay uncle in the original film). Lin-Manuel Miranda’s songs are often not good (though the song ‘Bye Bye’ might have been ruined by having a non-singer sing the song). The effects of the lions do look rather good (and much better than the 2019 film). The two hours also never bog down; the film is surprisingly brisk while also never being frantic in an attempt to keep the pace up. Though, still it ends up being a mediocre-at-best cash grab. [Black Reel – Outstanding Voice Performance Nominee], *Disney+*.
145. **Despicable Me 4:** The film is often more a collection of gags than a coherent piece. And for the most part that would be a detriment, but most of the gags are rather good (the Dance Dance Revolution gag is most likely the best). Which, at this point in the franchise, isn’t that what we want? Oddball gags that make you laugh? I’m not gonna overthink criticizing the flaws (Will Ferrell as a French guy is one of them) and say there are enough gags to make the film an enjoyable 90 minutes. [Annie – Best Storyboarding], *Netflix*.
144. **Miller’s Girl:** The film is not as bad as the various reviews imply (perhaps a few critic’s were too put-off by the subject matter?). The dialogue is often cheesy (not even Jenna Ortega and Martin Freeman can save most of it). And the last third of the film goes off the rails without much warning (and does so in a way that ‘wraps’ things up far too quickly, whereas the first portion of the film could have either been quick or actually expanded on the character development. As there is a good erotic thriller to be made here with the characters and the actors involved. The Gothic mood is often good, but rarely leaned into enough (besides a mildly bizarre fantasy sequence). For fans of erotic thrillers, Martin Freeman, or Jenna Ortega the film can still be worth watching. [Jenna Ortega], *Netflix*.
143. **That Christmas:** A Netflix animated film, about – you guessed it – Christmas. The Christmas setting kneecaps the film before it even starts, as it is a family-friendly feel-good adventure with some nice voice over from Brain Cox as Santa. There are multiple stories, but only the twin sisters subplot is rather enjoyable, as all the other subplots have been done before. The animation itself isn’t that good, especially the bodies are often lazily outlined. [Annie – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
142. **His Three Daughters:** Written and directed by Azazel Jacobs (*French Exit*), all of the films issues are a direct result of his lazy writing and odd directing. The dialogue is bizarrely written such that none of the characters feel real (it seems to lazily hope that because the film is about an impending death in the family, the audience can believe this characters are real). Elizabeth Olsen slightly overacts. Carrie Coon (*The Nest*) is the worst offender of the overacting; with two actresses overacting one has to assume it was a choice from the director. The only real character is that of the boyfriend. Everyone else is a lazy caricature. Any emotional impact that the climax has falls flat because the hour-twenty before it is a poorly written chore. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film], *Netflix*.
141. **Beetlejuice Beetlejuice:** A sequel that isn’t exactly disappointing, but also it wasn’t needed. The plot itself has a few too many subplots: the soul sucker, everything involving Justin Theroux’s character, shark-bitten husband, and it pains me to say it: everything involving William Dafoe’s character. Whereas the main plot of Lydia Deetz’ character and her daughter (played by a solid Jenna Ortega) works, it is not given enough room to breath. A better script could have allowed for a more focused film on the talents of Ryder and Ortega and of course Keaton. The film is also PG-13, and in an era where horror-comedy is more mainstream, the lack of an R-rating does hurt a bit. Lastly, most of one’s view will come down to how much enjoyment they get out of the absurdest wedding climax. [Sequel], *HBOMax* and *Netflix*.

140. **Gasoline Rainbow:** Another entry in the teen road-film genre. At times the film feels more like a documentary; including ‘philosophic’ voice-overs. The documentary-nature of the film does get annoying and one almost assumes the dialogue was all improvised given how little of it there is and how iffy it is. This does not give the film as much realism as the directors hoped. It makes the characters too thin and the various episodes boring. Also the lack of good dialogue makes the voice-overs more jarring. The film is too boring and too haphazard to ever excel. [Well-reviewed Drama]
139. **Your Monster:** If I had a nickel for every girl-falls-in-love-with-a-monster movie on this list I’d have two nickels. *Your Monster* and *Lisa Frankenstein* are hard to separate as they both suffer from the same primary flaw: inconsistent tone. Trying to balance comedy, horror, and romance is difficult. This film gets the balance slightly worse, partially as it wants to be a little more satirical (a man writes a play about women’s struggles) which doesn’t work as well as *Lisa’s* throwback campiness. Melissa Barrera (*Carmen*) is rather good and shows a wide range of talents (and slightly better than the leads in *Lisa*). She and Tommy Dewey are good together and elevate the film. [Well-reviewed Horror], *HBOMax*.
138. **Lisa Frankenstein:** An 80s-throwback horror-comedy that only really works because of Kathryn Newton (*The Map of Tiny Perfect Things*) and the sets/costumes leaning into being the 80s without going over-the-top. It also personally helps me that the film has multiple silent film references. Now the laughs aren’t as frequent as they should be to really elevate the film. Also the film gets to be tonally inconsistent in the second half, with too many plot themes (where does the romance with the Creature really come from? All these deaths?). Yet it remains a fun late-night watch, especially if you like the 80s or Kathryn Newton. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Peacock*.
137. **Fly Me to the Moon:** This is about as good as a movie you can make with a great cast, a large budget, and no real script. Scarlett Johansson (*Marriage Story*) and Channing Tatum (*Logan Lucky*) are capital A-list movie stars and can carry the film thru its lulls, detours, and oddities (almost all of ScarJo’s character is forced character development). Peppering in favorites in supporting roles helps the film; Woody Harrelson (*The Edge of Seventeen*), Ray Ramono (*Paddleton*), and Jim Rash (*Community*). The film has no business being two-hours-and-ten-minutes long, had it been cut down to an hour-forty perhaps it could move up a tier. Once the plot detours into faking the moon landing, it starts going down gill. But enjoy the easy watch and movie stars being charming. [Great Cast], *AppleTV+*.
136. **Kingdom of the Planet of the Apes:** Perhaps the main issue with the film (and a reason in a few years it could even rank higher) is that we did not need another *Apes* trilogy seven years after the reboot. And this film is very much setting up a new trilogy; the human character is a plot device who is not developed (but the audience knows the second installment will rectify this is lengthy flashbacks or monologues). Likewise the lore of ‘The Order of Caesar’ will surely be expanded upon in future films. Disney bought the rights to the franchise and instantly wanted to cash in. The CGI of the apes does look excellent and will deserve the VFX nominations it receives. But the film is a little too long and is more interested in setting up the next trilogy instead of being its own individual film. [Oscars – Best VFX Nominee], *Hulu*.
135. **Immaculate:** If I had a nickel for every evil-Catholics-force-a-naive-lady-to-give-birth-to-the-anti-christ movie I watched this year, I’d have two nickels. As this film is very similar to *The First Omen* (which itself is very similar to *Apartment 7A*). I get why we are having films about being forced to give birth to the anti-christ, but at least make them good. Sydney Sweeney is good in the film, but the script and direction is often poor. The first hour (of a ninety minute) film is a slog without much mystery or fright or suspense. The film starts so slow it needed an ‘unrelated’ opening sequence to keep the audience invested. And it is sad, as the last thirty minutes are good; especially everything

in the catacombs. The birthing scene is a long take. It gets good, but by time it does too much time has passed. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.

Tier 12: Hodgepodge of Stuff That Isn't Exactly Good, But Also Not Exactly Bad

134. **Sasquatch Sunset:** Easily one of the more unique films on the list. There is no dialogue, only the grunts from the titular Sasquatches (Sasquatchi?) and various nature sounds. The cast has big names, but given that they are in full Sasquatch costumes, their known talent does not come through. Even at 90 minutes, the film often feels slow. Yet, there are some funny moments (especially the ending). The film is what you would think a year in the life of a semi-intelligent Sasquatch would be. Despite how slow it is, and that the laughs are not enough (nor is the drama) to carry the film, it is hard not to appreciate the risk taken. [Was at Sundance]
133. **Fancy Dance:** Almost all of the issues with the film are a result of director and co-writer Erica Tremblay's script. There are multiple clichés: Child Protective Services taking the kid away from her aunt, to be placed with her rich (and white) (and off reservation) grand-father and *step*-grandmother; the step-grandmother being unlikable; commenting multiple times about how the cops will look for a missing child at the bequest of white people but not her own missing mother on the reservation; ohh and ICE shows up randomly because the film needed even more forced social commentary. The last fifteen minutes also go off the rails. However, Lily Gladstone (*Killers of the Flower Moon*) and Isabel Deroy-Olson are both rather good and their scenes together are good. But still not enough to overcome a weak and lazy plot. [GLAAD – Best Streaming Film Nominee], *AppleTV+*.
132. **Summer Solstice:** A low-budget film about college friends who reconnect, except one is a trans-man which causes issues. The script itself is okay, but none of the actors are able to bring much to the table. They are never bad, but unable to convey deeper meaning. The deeper meaning is needed as, again, the script itself is lacking. The characters are decent, and it could have added something to the LGBT genre about friends reconnecting post-transition, yet it never quite gets it. [Positive Review on LAist's film Week]
131. **Kid Snow:** The problem with a boxing movie in 2024, is that it is nearly impossible to add anything new to the genre. And sadly the ending is new enough, but it gets bogged down by tropes we've seen a thousand times: brothers, taking a fall, car crash after a defeat, meeting a single woman with a kid, etc. Some of the sets are good, but often they are sparse and cheap (most of the boxing scenes look cheap as the film did not have a budget to pack an arena with extra or CGI). Also for a film about a traveling carnival in the Outback, the film missed opportunities to have landscape shots and stress the traveling aspect of the carnival. Phoebe Tonkin (*Babylon*) is rather good as the single-mom-turned-dancer and steals nearly every scene she is in. [AACTA – Best Actress Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
130. **Maria:** The third famous-woman biopic from Pablo Larraín (*Jackie* and *Spencer*). This film continues to have the same great production values of the previous two, though the costumes are the weakest of the three. However the sets are gorgeous (it does help that most of the operatic scenes are filmed inside La Scala). The cinematography is rather nice, but I would not have nominated. Angelina Jolie is decent, but I am baffled by the high praise her performance received (the singing you hear is almost always the real Maria Callas). Between the worst costumes and the worst leading-lady performance this is easily the weakest of the three films. It attempts a somewhat interesting approach to the biopic with quaalude-induced hallucinations of a film crew making a documentary about her. But the film never leans into the premise enough for the film to escape biopic conventions. The flashbacks are in black and white, and they look especially good. The dialogue is often bad and comes

across as trying to be witty, but failing miserably at it. [Oscars – Best Cinematography Nominee], *Netflix*.

129. **Mean Girls:** The stage adaptation of the musical gets a few things wrong and perhaps missed what made the original film so good: Lindsey Lohan was the least talented main character! (Rachel McAdams, Amanda Seyfried, Lizzy Caplan, and Lacey Chabert are all better. Lohan was famous.) While this film, Angourie Rice (*Honor Society*) plays Cady and is the most talented actor of the kids. Renée Rapp (a replacement in the Broadway production) is not a good enough actor, and it needs to be said, she does not look the part of the most popular girl in high school. (A lengthy side bar is required to mention the costume designer did an awful job. These ‘kids’ do not look like high schools in 2023/4. Too much effort is made to re-create some looks from the original film. When one of the things the original film did so well was capture the look of 2004). The film does have some nice casting updates for the adults and a few easter eggs. It also doesn’t help that the songs are not that good. It is a solid collection of talent, with some decent jokes. If you are a fan of the original film, you won’t hate yourself watching this one night. [GLAAD – Best Wide Release Nominee], *Paramount+*.
128. **Problemista:** The surreal humor and writing do not work (those that buy-in probably have this at least three tiers higher). The timely comments on the immigrant experience are appreciated, but the surrealism detracts. Written, directed and starring Julio Torres, his sketches work in small doses, but when combined together, the film is not coherent. Characters are written in such a way that does beyond over-the-top. Thankfully, Tilda Swinton has such a blast with her character that she nearly carries and saves the film from itself. Her character is a caricature of a caricature, and somehow Swinton delivers such a funny performance, one is almost able to forget how poorly written the character is for a minute. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Nominee], *HBOMax*.
127. **Alien: Romulus** Co-written and directed by Fede Álvarez (*Don’t Breathe*), the film isn’t a exactly a worthy installment in the franchise, but it is a massive improvement over the most recent *Prometheus* films (especially when compared to what *Prey* did for *Predator*). Although *Romulus* tries to get back to the horror roots, the film itself is not that scary and is entirely reliant on the final twenty minutes to salvage a decent review (even then the finale was a massive Chekhov Gun that people should have seen coming), as the first hour does drag. There were probably far too many fan-service Easter eggs (most of which I missed). Even with the lack of scares, the primary issue was poor writing. The character were rarely developed and were often one-note (the anti-android cousin being the worst offender). Cailee Spaeny (*Priscilla*) is decent, and she’s only decent because she’s given so little to work with. The rest of the cast is mainly forgettable, especially sad is the casting of Archie Renaux (*The Other Zoey*) who can’t match Spaeny; if the love interest is mis-matched it becomes hard for the film to work; the first hour is a slog for a reason. Now the sets and props are nice, but they can’t overcome a mediocre script. [Oscars – Best VFX Nominee], *Hulu*.
126. **Trust:** A low-budget indie, that I have no idea how it made its way onto the list as it has no major nomination, and doesn’t appear to have been reviewed by critic’s I follow. Perhaps because it is a common film name, and films with this name have been on prior lists I thought I was adding an older film to my Amazon Watchlist? Either way, this indie ends up being decent. The script itself is solid, but the various no-name actors can not give the film the gravitas the script calls for. Where the script falters is that it tries to fit in too much in the aftermath of a death in the family. Building out the main scenes instead of adding more scenes would have been more effective. [I Literally Have No Idea]
125. **The Room Next Door:** The first English-language film from writer-director Pedro Almodóvar (*Parallel Mothers*), and although I’ve only seen one of his films, this one has the same issues. The dialogue is stilted—even Julianne Moore and Tilda Swinton have a hard time delivering the lines and they are two great actors! John Turturro shows up and adds nothing to plot except some forced

and preachy political statements. The film wants to say something about euthanasia, but it ends up saying very little. Some of the sets and costumes are nicely designed. And as the film goes along Tilda Swinton is able to carry it thru the bad parts. One wonders if the lavishing of awards the film received in Europe was a result of Jean-Luc Goddard recently dying via euthanasia. Yet, for the most part it is another miss from Pedro Almodóvar. [Golden Globes – Best Actress in a Drama Nominee], *Netflix*.

124. **I Used to Be Funny:** All of the film's flaws are a direct result of writer-director Ally Pankiw (her film directorial debut). The film's primary sin is its non-linear narrative, which adds nothing to the film (and astute viewers can probably piece together the big reveal after thirty minutes; why is it being withheld?). For a film about a comedian, the jokes are lacking (admittedly the film is a dramedy, but the jokes are there), and worst of all the jokes which are present are a very-specific-type of joke that permeates the 'modern' comedic style (especially those of unfunny queer women; Pankiw worked on *Schitt's Creek*) where comedy is a form a self-therapy meant to make the audience feel good. In fact, the funniest joke is told by the 'villain' comedian, 'man, you can now tell jokes about anything' (to Rachel Sennott's (obviously Jewish) character. Thankfully Rachel Sennott (*Shiva Baby* and *Bottoms*) is great and shows real dramatic chops after multiple comedies. Olga Petsa is also good in the key supporting role. But the performances are wasted by writer-director Ally Pankiw. [Well-reviewed Drama], *Netflix*.
123. **Backspot:** The rare cheerleader movie that appears to take its cheerleading premise seriously. Outside of the fact most of the actors do not look like high schoolers, the film treats its sport with respect (outside of one scene with a minor character disparaging the 'sport'). The constant focus on the lead character's nervous tick gets grating (two times is enough, yet it goes to the well at least six times). Another drawback is that the 'new' team does not appear to have an established leader; it is outsourced to the coaches played by Evan Rachel Wood (*Kajillionaire*) and Thomas Antony Olajide who are both rather good (and offer opposite methods of leadership). The film doesn't mark debut director D. W. Waterson as someone to watch, but rather the film is a tight 90 minutes, with solid character development. [GLAAD – Outstanding Limited Release Nominee]
122. **The End We Start From:** The film is based on a novel of the same name, which I have not read. I assume that most of the film's issues are a result of directly adapting the novel; the film feels episodic and jumps around both time and location without much explanation. In a novel, this can work with starting a new chapter, but in a film the lack of transitions do not work. For example: a family is giving away food (the mom was a hoarder) and then the film jumps to needing to secure food; the slow transition from abundance to scarcity would have been a time to develop characters. Jodie Comer is the main bright spot of the film, but even she can't overcome the film's flaws. Joel Fry (*Cruella*) continues to put in solid supporting performances. Benedict Cumberbatch show up for a scene (again, the film is episodic) and crushes it (he was a producer on the film). Despite wanting to say something about climate change and motherhood, the film never manages to say much of anything beyond what Jodie Comer wills onto the screen. [BIFA – Best Lead Performance Nominee], *Hulu*.
121. **The Gutter:** A bowling comedy that is rather crazy. The jokes don't always keep place, and the film has plot holes. Yet it is still hilarious (at times) with solid actors and cameos. Shameik Moore (*Spiderverse*) and D'Arcy Carden (*The Good Place*) are the leads and are great together. Both Susan Sarandon and Paul Reiser are funny in supporting roles. The cameos are wide-ranging: Adam Pally, Adam Brody, Nelson Franklin, and Paul Scheer. Enjoy the crazy laughs, the familiar plot, and ignore some of the issues. [Well-reviewed Comedy], *Hulu*.
120. **Abigail:** The film succeeds because it knows what it is. Any film about a vampire ballerina child needs to be campy fun. This is campy fun with gallons of blood. Co-directors Matt Bettinelli-Olpin

and Tyler Gillett (*Ready or Not*) are good at this specific-type of horror subgenre. The film is also aided by a sneaky good cast; Melissa Barrera (*Your Monster* and *In the Heights*), Dan Stevens (*The Rental*), and Kathryn Newton (*List Frankensteins*) and others are all good in their roles. Yes, the premise is silly, and maybe it does not need to be nearly two-hours, but it is a campy and fun late-night watch. [Critic's Choice – Best Young Actor Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

119. **Cuckoo:** I can not get past the campy-and-creepy performance from Dan Stevens (*Abigail*), except the film itself it rarely campy. Steven's character is so oddball that the audience instantly knows something is up, but not in a good way; it is over-the-top acting that sets the mood not the plot or shots (and some of the shots are nice). The plot itself is new enough and Hunter Schafer is decent. But because the film never leans into the camp, it ends up being in this awkward range where it scares rarely scare and its absurdity does not translate. [Independent Spirit – Best Lead Performance Nominee], *Hulu*.
118. **Inside Out 2:** Although another cash grab from Disney/Pixar, this sequel at least had something new say and add to the franchise (unlike *Moana 2* which was a lazy rehashing of *Moana*). Except this film misses the opportunity to really work with its concept and characters (it doesn't help that the writers forgot that Joy was the most annoying part of the first film; though they remembered Disgust was a character!). The film starts with Riley finding out her 'old' friends are moving, and will then be heading to High School alone. Yet, instead of realizing that a) her 'old' friends are kinda losers (they meet because one dropped stuff all over the classroom) and b) part of growing up is moving on from 'old' friends. Yet [spoiler? nah you'll see it coming a mile away] Riley finds a way to keep her old friends and make new ones! The film wants too hard to be family-friendly (forgetting that those who grew up with the original film are now teenagers and can handle some actual heartbreak). The film also forgets that Riley initially found Joy in playing hockey (also the writers never watched a game of hockey in their lives based on how poorly the hockey scenes were written; Riley STEALS THE PUCK FROM HER OWN TEAMMATE, and is somehow not immediately benched). There are semi-forced mixed-animation scenes which almost seem more forced than anything; as it is a popular new-er way of animating films—here though it does not work and feels like an inorganic attempt at adding some artistic credibility to a cash grab. It does not really work and we should start considering this recent era of Disney/Pixar films and 'The Lazy Age'. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Disney+*.
117. **The First Omen:** If I had a nickel for every prequel-about-birthing-the-anti-christ I watched this year, I'd have two nickels. Which isn't a lot. This film is not very scary, and the bright warm lighting choices in the first two-thirds are a little off-putting for a horror. The film was the directorial debut of Arkasha Stevenson who can hopefully do good things going forward. As the film does a solid job of fitting itself into an existing franchise, while also being its own film. Ralph Ineson does a good job as Father Brennan (a key supporting character in the original film); one believes they are the same character. Nell Tiger Free is decent in the leading role, but nothing special. For a forced franchise entry, the film stands on its own. [*The Omen* Franchise]

Tier 11: The Performances Save Most of These

116. **The Thicket:** A snow-scaped western that wants to be a slow-burn film, but the drama is never enough to carry the film to the finish line. The set up is classic: a brother has his sister stolen by a gang of vigilantes and he then teams up with a rag-tag group to chase them down and save her. Although each character has a reason for joining the manhunt, the film never gets into enough depth on each. Peter Dinklage is solid as the bounty hunter, while Levon Hawke leaves a bit to be desired as the brother. Juliette Lewis is also decent as the gang-leader, but again the script lets down all of the characters. The film often looks great and the snow-covered mountains are beautiful. [Well-reviewed Drama], *Amazon Prime*.

115. **The Outrun:** Saoirse Ronan is great, as she always is. She absolutely carries the film. The film is technically well-made yet often feels like another entry in the recovering-alcoholic genre. The character's infatuation with Scottish lore reminds me of the stories present in Tamm Moore's Irish Folklore Trilogy of animated films (which are superior). And the love of the unnatural does not exactly fit with wanting to be a biologist. The final speech about wanting to study seaweed comes across as preachy. The supporting characters are not exactly developed, but rather exist to help explain Ronan's alcoholism and the pressures she faces in recovery (hint: it's the parents). Through it all, Ronan is still great. [BAFTA– Best Actress Nominee], *Netflix*.
114. **Lee:** If I had a nickel for every female-war-photographer film I watched this year, I'd have two nickels. The issue with this biopic is that *Civil War* came out the same year. Although this film is a biopic, based on very real events, it is still inferior to *Civil War*. The first half of the film is standard biopic-fare, complete with the female character needing to fight for her spot at the table. The dialogue is also often poor, especially everything set in the French Riviera. The cast itself is stacked: Kate Winslet is the lead, Andy Samberg (*Palm Springs*), Alexander Skarsgård (*The Northman*), Marion Cotillard (*Allied*), Andrea Riseborough (*To Leslie*), Noémie Merlant (*Portrait of a Lady on Fire*), and Josh O'Connor (*Emma*) yet sadly almost none of them are given much chance to shine but are all often good (the script isn't good). The final third gets better but mainly because of the emotional impact of the holocaust and the bread scene is moving and the other images horrific. The stellar cast can't overcome a weak script, and film that made similar points but better was also made this year. [Golden Globes – Best Actress in a Drama Nominee], *Hulu*.
113. **Suncoast:** I should mention that I am not the audience for this film as it is about hospice and a kid who is a vegetable. So the drama about the mom and sister trying to live their lives does not land with me. Also the Terri Schiavo ordeal is shoe-horned into the plot as a way of introducing Woody Harrelson's character. Harrelson is good, but his character could have been better and more natural. It is also a slight departure from his usual role in coming-of-age films. Laura Linney (*Wildcat*) overdoes it and her character is poorly written. The best part is Nico Parker (*The Last Of Us*) and that the film does capture the early 00s with its sets and costumes. But the general plot is generic (sans the hospice brother, and Terri Schiavo) so the film has a hard time excelling. [Black Reel – Best Cinematography Nominee], *Hulu*.
112. **In Camera:** A surrealist/fantasy about trying to become an actor and being middle-eastern in England (what is it with British films this year and fantasy sequences?). The film is also in the awkward middle-ground where it does not embrace its surrealism but it has too much of it to work. There is a doctor character, who does not do much (one could argue it is a manifestation of the main character's attempt to be successful; but again—the film never leans into it the premise). Being in that awkward middle portion is the major flaw of this movie: it wants to do a bit of everything, but never ends up committing to doing much of anything. [British Independent Film – Best Lead Performance Nominee]
111. **A Quiet Place: Day One:** I still believe this franchise is overrated, and I am not exactly sure it needed a prequel. I even missed that two characters are from *Part II*, so perhaps people who enjoy the franchise will get a lot more out of it. Michael Sarnoski (*Pig*) directs and it doesn't have scares, or thrills. For a film that wants to partially be about NYC, it rarely feels like NYC (the background VFX are partially to blame). Lupita Nyong'o is great as always, and without her the film would be multiple tiers lower. Yet one wishes that the end product was just better and how Nyong'o and Joseph Quinn's (*Stranger Things*) characters get together isn't exactly flushed out; he sorta starts following her (despite it being obvious she is not heading towards safety). [Prequel], *Paramount+*.
110. **The Dead Don't Hurt:** Written, directed, starring, and composed by Viggo Mortensen, and film would have been much better if he only did one-and-a-half of those. He does a good job directing

and captures some beautiful shots. He is a decent co-lead. His script is far too basic (you've seen most of it a thousand times before; it needed to expand on the immigrant experience and the Civil War setting). In addition to the basic script, with its carton villains, it is slow. At two-hours-ten the script is too long, and his poor score can't hold the viewers attention while the film drags. Thankfully Vicky Krieps (*Phantom Thread*) is great and carries the film. [Viggo Mortensen]

109. **Big Boys:** A movie that should be a tender coming-of-age film. Yet, the lead character is written (and then acted) in such an annoying manner, I kept wanting him to be bullied (yeah yeah, I am going to hell). So the main character who is suppose to be awkward-but-sympathetic comes across as the world's biggest loser. When the older man takes interest (he was also a younger brother) it comes across as a little forced, because the kid that annoying. Likewise the main character's brother is written as overly mean, in an attempt to force sympathy. Which is sad, as there are some small details that get called back and it is an LGBT coming-of-age that is not often told. Except, sometimes bullying is good, as certain behaviors are annoying to the rest of us. [Independent Spirit – Best Breakthrough Performance Nominee]
108. **Hard Truths:** Once again, a film ruined by a main character that is not a character, but a caricature. Marianne Jean-Baptiste does play the role well, but the character itself is not a real person. Instead the film wants the viewer to sympathize for the main caricature because [your pick of sociology bs: generational trauma, systemic racism, grief, mental health issues]. But anyone in real life who acted like the main caricature would be divorced and their family would stop reaching out. (It's likely the film's ambiguity towards the protagonist's issues allows each person to cast their own issues onto the character.) I'd also go even further to say that if the cast wasn't led by black women, but white men, the film would not have received good reviews, the same goes if it had a no-name director instead of Mike Leigh (*Mr. Turner*). Thankfully the film was frequently left out of major awards. [BAFTA – Best Actress Nominee]
107. **Sebastian:** A film about gay prostitution, whose flaws become very apparent if one has watched *Anora*. Although the wrinkle of gay prostitution is different, the general statements and characterization are done far better in *Anora*, making the character development in this film rather weak. The same few threads are explored, but rarely expanded on, and the film builds up to a basic character insight. Ruairidh Mollica is good in the lead and therefore able to keep the film going thru its lulls. The sex scenes are intense. [British Independent Film – Best Breakthrough Performance Nominee]
106. **The Kitchen:** A dystopian film about a futuristic London that gets muddled in its own ideas. Firstly, the film has some of the worst sound mixing I've heard in a while (the dialogue is nearly inaudible, unless the volume is up). However, as with all movies with housing as an issue, it gets its main issue wrong for cheap social points. As a friendly reminder, building more new housing lowers the price of housing (so many films about 'gentrification—because in art facts don't matter as much as feelings—fail for that very reason). The film is co-directed by Kibwe Tavares and Daniel Kaluuya; Tavares past as an architect allows for nice shots as he definitely has an eye for structure. Yet the minimalist approach to the world-building does not work and makes the almost-two-hour film drag. [BIFA – Best VFX], *Netflix*.
105. **Out of Darkness:** A 'horror' (more of a thriller) set in 45,000 BC. Given the Stone Age setting, a fake language is used for the dialogue, which does not exactly add to the plot. It does make sense to not use english (some of which risk spoilers), but it detracts more than it adds. The film relies on a simple premise of humanity and society (I think part of the good reviews simply liked the social commentary about the need to trust our fellow man), as the scares are never there. Likewise the events that really get at the social commentary do not really land, and in many ways are forced. Yet the setting, forest cinematography, and costumes are good, the film doesn't come together as well as it should have. [BIFA – Debut Screenwriter Nominee]

104. **Kung Fu Panda 4:** After the fourth film, one wondered if the franchise needed to continue as it ended on a solid note. Yet, this installment (for the most part) works. Obvious there are some plot issues; these people didn't know about this city loaded with evil-doers? Jack Black is great as always in this role, and the film manages to introduce new characters (and the possibility of a fifth and final installment), even if most of the regular characters are eschewed to make room in the plot. Viola Davis shows that being a great actor and having a distinct voice is not enough to be a great voice actor. The animation again looks good. The film leaves open an easy possibility of a fifth film that hopefully does let the franchise down. [Annies – Best Animated Feature Nominee], *Netflix*.
103. **MaXXXine:** One of the major disappointments on this list. The third (and final?) film in Ti West's *X* series (*X* and *Pearl*); both films I had in the Top-25 for 2022. And this is a poor conclusion to the series. While *X* was a good old-school, throwback horror film and *Pearl* was an excellent character study with a tour de force from Mia Goth, *MaXXXine* never figured out what it wanted to be. The production design is still solid, but the plot outline does not work. (It felt like a rough idea was half-developed, and committed to, but once it wasn't going to work out, it needed to be scrapped completely). It wants to be a modern update on slasher films and B-horror, but the film is never campy enough. The character of Maxine is underdeveloped and therefore Mia Goth can't shine thru (the character wasn't that developed in *X*, but remember it was a good horror and was a good update on *Texas Chainsaw Massacre*). While *Pearl* was rushed into production and turned out great, this film comes across as a forced and half-hearted attempt at another franchise installment. [Sequel], *HBOMax*.
102. **Ultraman: Rising** The main reason the film ranks here is that the animation is often beautiful. The colors are great and the mixed styles frequently work (when the kaijus fall into the water the multiple styles really work). Though there are a few instances where the styles do not mesh (these weird spirals before a character throws a punch). Most all of the baseball stuff is awful (no one holds baseball players responsible for not winning a championship; but I appreciate the Dodgers going all-in on the Japanese market, and the animation of Dodgers Stadium looked great). The plot is a generic family plot and never really figures out what it wants to say about parenting (it is hard? but worth it; it is too surface level—there will be another film on this list that gets the issues of parenting perfect). It also does not help that the villain is a cartoon villain, and no one scene of 'backstory' does not give him enough characterization to overcome being a cartoon villain. [Annies – Best Feature Nominee], *Netflix*.
101. **Sweethearts:** A college comedy about breaking up with your high school sweetheart, so the premise is new enough and the opening credits convey backstory setting up the film to succeed. Yet the script eventually lets the film down. Kiernan Shipka (*Totally Killer*) is rather good and carries the film, except the co-lead of Nico Hiraga (*Rosaline*) is not able to match her. The script doesn't develop the soon-to-be exes well enough. The side plot with Caleb Hearon and Tramell Tillman's (*Severance*) characters is almost better than the main plot, but that is primarily a statement of Tillman's quality (Unrelated: Can we get a buddy-cop blaxploitation film with Tillman and Colman Domingo as the co-leads? That is how good Tillman is in everything.) The jokes stop landing as well, and the film takes a few too many plot liberties. Whereas if the film stayed more grounded in reality, with a few more joke the film could easily catapult a few tiers. [GLAAD – Outstanding Streaming Film Nominee], *HBOMax*.
100. **We Live in Time:** The film is actually a rom-com, but it is directed as a romantic melodrama. That the director did not know the film he was directing hurts the ranking along. Instead of laughs, the film is constantly aiming for tears. Director John Crowley (*Brooklyn*) decisions nearly ruin the movie. For example, Pugh's character gives birth in a gas station bathroom; after accidentally locking herself in. This situation is hilarious. Instead the movie goes for the perseverance angle. Andrew Garfield and Florence Pugh are both good, as to be expected. Without them the film melodrama is

most certainly a chore and possibly even dips into so-bad-its-good territory given the film is actually a comedy. [Pugh and Garfield], *HBOMax*.

99. **Carry-On:** If the viewer can accept the premise of the film: trying to get a carry-on thru TSA so terrorism(?) can be achieved, the film is enjoyable (though it is easy to see that the film has multiple bridges too far, and the view taps out). The film mainly works because Taron Egerton (*Tetris*) and Jason Bateman (*Air*) are good and enjoyable. Bateman's hypnotic instructions work and the viewer is able to buy-in (again, there are a lot of iffy plot points, but you forgive them and enjoy the ride; or move this down two tiers). But perhaps this is what should be expected from bigger-budget director Jaume Collet-Serra (*Jungle Cruise* and *Black Adam*) as we are a long ways away from *The Shallows*. [PGA – Best Streaming Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
98. **Sonic the Hedgehog 3:** The rare franchise that keeps getting better as it continues, perhaps because it is one of the most self-aware franchises. The voices of Ben Schwartz, Colleen O'Shaughnessey, Idris Elba, and now Keanu Reeves are all great. The film finds ingenious ways of bringing back minor characters from the previous films (Natasha Rothwell and Adam Pally's brief appearances are the best; Rothwell has a single scene and nearly steals the entire film). Yet again, the best part of the film (and franchise) is Jim Carrey. This time he plays not only Dr Robotnik but also Robotnik's grandfather. You can only imagine the hijinks and kookiness Carrey is able to get up to when playing dual roles. As a mild spoiler there is a dance number. It might be the funniest thing on film this year. The film won't make you think, but it is fun and the best in the franchise (so far). [Sequel], *Paramount+*.
97. **Deadpool and Wolverine:** The third film in the *Deadpool* franchise is able to keep the R-rated fun going. Ryan Reynolds has perfected the character and the mood of the franchise (he is one of the co-writers of the script). The film does a great job of balancing the (forgotten) superhero films of the early-to-mid 00s, Disney's purchase of 20th Century Fox (and therefore X-Men), and the current state of the MCU. Although the *Spider-verse* films and the Tom Holland *Spider-Man* films have done most of it already (and better), this film does so with humor and the requisite mocking of the entire idea of these cinematic (and tv) universes. Hugh Jackman is good as always and there are multiple great cameos. Cassandra Nova is especially good in her role, while one wishes the film got more use out of Matthew Macfadyen (*Succession*). That the franchise has gotten three solid films out of a singular premise, insulting the current state of superhero movies, is an accomplishment. [Critic's Choice – Best Comedy], *Disney+*.

Tier 10: Fun Watches and Meh Biopics

96. **Shirley:** A generic biopic about the first Black Woman congressmen, Shirley Chisholm. The biopic focuses on her 1972 primary campaign for the Democratic Presidential Nomination. It paints Chisholm in too nice a light (her looming divorce is hinted at in a few scenes, but not given much weight). It falls into all the standard traps of middling biopics. The VFX often look cheap (especially scenes where they added in the DC skyline). Regina King (*If Beale Street Could Talk*) is good in the lead role, but not good enough to overcome the film's many flaws. The supporting cast is rather good as well; Lance Reddick, Terrence Howard, and Lucas Hedges among others. Yet it never comes together to offer anything new. Some of the costumes are nice. [Black Reel – Outstanding Lead Performance Nominee], *Netflix*.
95. **The Great Lillian Hall:** Yet another film about dementia that adds nearly nothing new to the subgenre. The only main attempt is a documentary structure at times, which doesn't exactly work. Jessica Lange (*Tootsie*) is solid in the leading role while Kathy Bates (*Misery*) is funny in a supporting role. Pierce Brosnan is charming, even if his character is jammed into the film as the neighbor for

balcony conversations. Watch good actors be good, but don't expect much else. [[Critic's Choice – Best Streaming Movie Nominee], *HBOMax*.

94. **Parallel:** The film is decent, and despite it being an adaptation of a 2019 Chinese film, it is in reality a worse version of *Coherence* (2014) (which ranked fifth on my 2014 list, it is an under-the-radar classic and one of the best sci-fi films). Therefore, once the film gets going (after about 20 minutes), the viewer will wish they were re-watching *Coherence*. Although this film attempts to add a few new wrinkles, they are not new enough to make the film stand out. Danielle Deadwyler (*Till*) is decent, but can't overcome some of the limitations based on the plot. Now go watch *Coherence*. [Black Reel – Outstanding First Screenplay Nominee]
93. **The Rooster:** The plot itself is a little shaky; a cop loses a childhood friend so he takes some time off to be alone in the woods where he meets a hermit played by Hugo Weaving. The two then slowly bond. Yet, the film never quite develops the main character played by Phoenix Raei. So although the two characters work well together; the eccentric and the reserved, and one enjoys watching the character hang out, the film often feels that there isn't anything going on under the surface. The last third takes a bit of a weird turn in an attempt to be a thriller, and it doesn't add much to the film, except to provide an ending to a film about two dudes who started hanging out in the woods. [AACTA – Best Independent Film Nominee]
92. **Drift:** Another film about the African Migrant Crisis in Europe (though vastly inferior to *His House*) that does bring enough new to the genre: Cynthia Erivo's character has a British accent and is therefore better able to blend in (and one or two others that risk spoilers). The primary issue is that the film wants to be too serious/artsy; dialogue is often eschewed for good-but-not-great photography. Neither Erivo or Alia Shawkat are good enough to keep the film moving. The film is never fully able to develop the characters because so much is left unsaid, in trying to be more artistic and daring, it ends up failing to land. [British Independent Film – Best Supporting Performance Nominee]
91. **Omni Loop:** Another entry in the Time-Loop genre, and one that never figures out what it wants to be. The premise is funny and should be treated as such; the lead has a black hole inside her that will kill her in a week; this is an absurdest premise! Yet the 'diagnosis' is delivered by a no-name actor matter-of-factly in the first minute; the audience instantly knows this film hasn't figured itself out (pay a great comedic actor for a day's work—call in a favor with a friend). So what could have become a tragicomedy fails to fully develop. Ayo Edebiri (*Theater Camp*) is in a supporting role for crying out loud! The film is also one of the few time-loops where characters are scientists, yet it never farms the idea that these characters should buy-in to one person being in a time-loop instantly (again it misses the comedic portion). The drama also then suffers as the film is too light-weight to deliver the serious parts about facing death. Thankfully both Mary-Louise Parker and Ayo Edebiri are able to overcome most of writer-director Bernardo Britto's faults. [Well-reviewed Sci-fi], *Hulu*.
90. **You'll Never Find Me:** A simplistic thriller-horror, that can't get enough out of its single-location two-actor premise to justify the hour and forty minutes. The film is moody with good sound design and lighting (lots of great shadowy and partially illuminated shots), and the mood helps with initial lulls. There are twists and turns for the first parts of the film and most of them work as the film keeps the viewer guessing which character is lying. Yet, eventually the film starts to drag and the final twist reveals itself a little before the film wants to reveal it. Then the ending is not exactly stuck. However, the first forty minutes is solid and compensates for the second half's downfall. [AACTA – Best Independent Film Nominee]
89. **Transformers One:** The goal is to survive the first thirty minutes until the film reach the 'surface' of the planet. As that first thirty minutes features some lazy dialogue and plot points and the animation

often looks eh. The only good thing about the first thirty minutes is the character voiced by Keegan-Michael Key's making a great *Key & Peele* reference. However, once on the surface, the animation quality greatly improves and the film starts to look beautiful. The voice cast is decent even is Chris Hemsworth basically plays Optimus Prime as Chris Hemsworth. The best are Brian Tyree Henry (*Causeway*) who helps sell the evil turn of Megatron and the previously mentioned Keegan-Michael Key who has fun with the absurdity of it. The plot itself is extremely predictable and a tad preachy, but for the *Transformers* franchise it is a huge leap forward. Don't let the franchise's quality scare you away from seeing this fun and decent film. [Annie – Best Voice Acting Nominee], *Paramount+* and *Amazon Prime*.

88. **Wallace & Gromit: Vengeance Most Fowl:** On paper I should really love this film. There are multiple references to other films and a bunch of cheese jokes (the re-boot joke might be the best). And yet, I never got behind the whimsy. There were never moments where I disliked the film (as other animated films in this tier had bad parts which one needed to survive), but there weren't any sequences I loved. The commentary on technology was nuanced so that was not an issue for me. I simply wished there was more here; perhaps some of the jokes were too British? Or perhaps as my friend suggested, my middling review is because I am "bitter and dead inside". [Oscars – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
87. **Thelma:** A funny-enough and sorta light-hearted film carried by June Squibb (*Blow the Man Down*); one even wonders if some of the good reviews are because, like me, the review was happy to see June Squibb to get the chance to carry a film and showcase her comedic chops. Some of the old people jokes get tiring, but at under 100 minutes, the film stays brisk. It is aided by amazing supporting actors: Richard Roundtree (*Shaft*) and Malcom McDowell (*A Clockwork Orange*) and Parker Posey (*Beau is Afraid*). A few more jokes would improve the film, but enough of them land and so do a lot of the themes regarding aging and loneliness. [Critics Choice – Best Comedy Nominee], *Hulu*.
86. **Good One:** Lily Collias (*Palm Trees and Power Lines*) is a revelation and carries the film. Her glances and looks add all the needed subtext required from the minimalist script; her, her dad, and his friend go on a three-day hike in the woods. The script from first-time writer-director India Donaldson is the main let down. The dad and his friends are in that range of not-complete-assholes but also not-that-good-of-people, and this film boils down to that (as a young woman) putting up with these men is draining. The two male characters do not have enough depth to make the film interesting; they keep doing slightly-annoying things and she must tolerate it. For example, the film takes 35 minutes to (attempt to) explain why the dad (an experienced hiker) would willingly invite his incompetent friend on a three-day hike. Another one, what idiot books a single hotel room for four people (one of the hikers canceled; what was the logistical thought process there besides being cheap? Except these are not-evil, but not-good people) That is a decision normal people would not make. Thankfully, Lily Collias is so good the slow pace, and lack of true character development are forgiven. The audience beyond taken with her skill and some beautiful outdoor photography. [Independent Spirit – Best First Screenplay Nominee]
85. **Violett:** A solid slow-burn psychological horror with a twist or three. Therefore specific plot points and details become difficult to convey (even if one of the twists might be obvious). The cinematography and production design are great for a low-budget film and really add to the sense of dread. The supporting actors are freaky and aided by close-up cinematography. One does wish the last twenty minutes came together a little better; again three twists to get thru. Making that section tighter and possibly chopping off ten or fifteen minutes would improve the film. Yet still what remains is a well-crafted psychological horror on a tiny budget. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Amazon Prime*.
84. **Strange Darling:** A thriller than benefits from its non-linear chapter structure. Though astute viewers will put it together in the 'second' chapter shown. The lighting is great, especially the blue

tones in the truck. The film succeeds because of Willa Fitzgerald (*Wildcat*) and Kyle Gallner (*Smile*). Both carry a dialogue-heavy Chapter One; Chapter One is easily the best of the six chapters. However, Chapter Six features a scene with such heavy-handed dialogue and bad acting (by the female cop in particular) it nearly ruins the movie; and makes you wonder if writer-director JT Mollner is talented or lucked out with Willa Fitzgerald putting in a tour de force. [Critic's Choice Super Awards – Best Actress in a Horror Nominee]

83. **Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga:** Another fun film in the ‘reboot’ of the *Mad Max* franchise. It features yet another epic chase sequence, it is beyond impressive that George Miller was able to create yet another (and given this is a prequel, the added difficulty of needing to make it more primitive). The five-act structure works, but might be a slight deterrence for some that want the non-stop adrenaline of the *Fury Road*. The editing is once again top notch. The sound design is good. Chris Hemsworth (*Extraction*) brings his charm, but his character could use some more fleshing out (one can argue a ‘normal’ villain was needed to contrast with the ghastly dudes from *Fury Road*). Anya Taylor-Joy is good as always even if she is not Charlize Theron. It isn’t as good as *Fury Road*, but still enjoyable. Though I was more down on *Fury Road* than most. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film], *HBOMax* and *Netflix*.
82. **Kinds of Kindness:** Anthology films are rarely my cup of tea, and it applies here as well. Each of the three ‘episodes’ is about fifty minutes, and one wishes they were more developed. The first two are the strongest episodes, and by time the third episode roles around the viewer does not want to become invested in another segment. Unlike the better Yorgos Lanthimos films the jokes do not land (*The Lobster* and *The Favourite*) nor does the creepiness set in (*The Killing of a Sacred Deer*). Yet, the film still has all his hallmarks of odd-jokes, creepy ideas, perverted sex, excellent camera work, and Emma Stone. Jesse Plemons is good, especially in the first two segments. Margaret Qualley is often better than Emma Stone, and it would have been nice if they switched roles in the last segment. That the major cast members have different roles in each segment is nice, but this ambitious project does not land. [Golden Globes – Best Actor in a Comedy Nominee], *Hulu*.
81. **Goodrich:** The film is so standard and filled with tropes, and yet none of it matters because Michael Keaton (*The Founder*) carries the film. The film has a balance of pathos and comedy which Keaton expertly switches between. It feels like an old-fashioned bittersweet comfort movie. Everytime one should do a facepalm for another cliché, the audience either laughs or cries because watching Keaton along with Mila Kunis, Michael Urie, and Andie MacDowell is a good time. [Michael Keaton], *HBOMax*.
80. **Magpie:** A solid slow-burn film about marriage, even if there might be a slight plot hole or two. The film is based on an idea from Daisy Ridley (*Murder on the Orient Express*) who also stars, though she did not write the script; her husband did (and it has a few great foreshadowing moments and callbacks). There are enough enough twists and turns to make the film enjoyable, despite having the basic premise of a husband potentially cheating on his potentially crazy wife. Going into more specifics risks spoilers. [Well-reviewed Thriller], *Hulu*.
79. **LaRoy, Texas:** A comedic noir that is at times a discount Coen Brothers film. The script has funny moments, but is rarely funny enough to keep the laughs going. Instead a fair bit of the jokes are a result of Steve Zahn (*Treme*) having a blast in his role as piss-poor PI. John Magaro (*First Cow*) is decent as the loser husband who gets caught up in the criminal goings-on. Similarly Dylan Baker is solid as the actual hitman. The script itself has a few too many callbacks; one or two really work (the car towing), but others (finish the job) are not necessary. Enjoy the semi-funny crime spree. [Well-reviewed Noir]
78. **The Last Stop in Yuma County:** A solid and brisk noir on a low-budget. First-time writer-director Francis Galluppi has a tight script that has some laughs and tension; a bit more of both would

move the film up about two tiers. Jim Cummings (*Thunder Road*) is great at playing a character he's perfected. Some of the cast delivers good performances, but one wishes their characters were developed a bit more (the film is only 90 minutes). Richard Brake (*Vesper*) is decent at the main villain but needed to be a tad better to carry the film. There aren't many real flaws, and shows the potential of the director, but a few slight changes and it could have been a lot better. [Well-reviewed Noir]

77. **Audrey:** A black-comedy that has multiple good jokes, even if its plot is a tad outlandish and at times more bits than a coherent plot. Jackie van Beek (*Nude Tuesday*) is good as the mother. The main premise of life improving if you no longer have a child for both parents and the other sibling is great. Your child/sister being in a coma, improving your life is hilarious and the films and quips and jokes to take the comedy beyond premise. The various sex jokes are funny, including a bizarre christian-themed porn shoots. Enjoy the fun and brisk black-comedy. [AACTA – Best Lead Actress Nominee]
76. **It's What's Inside:** A film whose concept is better than its execution. The film takes a novel approach to the body-swap genre; a long-lost-friend-turned-tech-genius shows up to a party before a friend's wedding with a machine that lets people swap bodies. It is a great idea for exploring the relationships and desires of the characters. Except the eight characters are not developed enough beyond generic platitudes. The lack of development hampers the film. The film's Coda is okay, but the people who like it are probably the people who should not be evaluating films. Better script with better actors could have greatly improved this novel take on the body-swap film. [Critic's Choice – Best Streaming Movie Nominee], *Netflix*.
75. **Twisters:** Let's bring back 90s-style blockbusters. Give me two hot and charming people falling in love and saving the day. Glen Powell (*Set It Up*) and Daisy Edgar-Jones (*Fresh*) are both so good. Witty, charming, and most-importantly they work perfectly together (sorry Anthony Ramos, this isn't about you). The scene where Glen Powell's character finally appears is the definition of electric. There is enough plot and character development that the viewer does not groan, a few throwbacks to the original *Twister* (which had a deeper cast, but Bill Paxton is no Glen Powell). The soundtrack is rather good. There is the exposition to 'explain' the 'science' but it isn't overbearing, and frequently combined with solid jokes. The film is two hours of fun (ignore the people that die and the towns destroyed), and even if there are a few better 'blockbusters' on the list, this one is still easily worth chasing. [Black Reel – Best Editing Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

Tier 9: Great Premises but Too Many Flaws to Really Excel

74. **Am I OK?:** Although the film is about a woman discovering her sexuality in her thirties, it functions best as a drama among friends. Each of those two plot elements are generally great. Dakota Johnson is solid in the lead and Sonoya Mizuno is decent in the supporting role. Except Mizuno's (natural) English accent dips into that faux-posh vocal range at times; making me want to rip out my own ear drums. The primary issue with the film is that although the ideas are good, they rarely get explored in enough depth; especially the coming-out plot lacks the specific touches one wants to elevate the film. It is Tig Notaro's feature film directorial debut and she doesn't bring anything to the film where she shows promise as a director. [GLAAD – Outstanding Streaming Film Nominee], *HBOMax*.
73. **Smile 2:** I am not sure this needed a sequel, or to become a franchise, but if the studio is going to throw the bag at you, why not. Writer-director Parker Finn mainly excels in the directing department; there are multiple (pseudo) long takes, including a lengthy 'single'-take shot to start the film. Some of the costumes are good. The film is not as scary as the first film (one of the items that helped elevate the first film's ranking). The major issue with the film is not the plot (of which there are some), but rather the sound mixing. The film lowers the volume of dialogue and then blasts the bass

during ‘scary’ scenes. Instead of letting the frights come naturally, the film attempts to force them on the audience by overdoing the bass. However, Naomi Scott (*Aladdin* and *Charlie’s Angels*) is great and carries the film thru its various lulls and bizarre turns (a lesser actress would have made the film so-bad-it-good instead of decent). Hopefully she gets to do some serious work in the future (which was also evident after her earlier work). If you enjoyed the first, this one is still worth watching even if it isn’t as good. [Critic’s Choice Super Awards – Best Actress in a Horror Nominee], *Paramount+* and *Amazon Prime*.

72. **The People’s Joker:** An independent film that might be copyright infringement (multiple Batman characters make appearances) shot of a budget of almost zero. The complete lack of budget at times makes the movie look extremely cheap. Bad green screens, characters in the same scene who are obviously not in the same room and have been edited together, animation that is awful. (There will be a film on this list that had a microscopic 250k budget and managed to look great, so it is a real distraction here.) Some of the gags and references to Batman are great, but the time between jokes is too long. The premise of a trans coming-of-age story is great, and it had the potential to be a cult classic. But the poor visuals and mediocre script hold it back; a more comedic Penguin would have greatly improved the film. Also, if I had a nickel for every film on this list with Lorne Micheals as a character, I’d have two nickels; the film has that much comedic potential. [Independent Spirit – John Cassavetes Award Nominee]
71. **The Fall Guy:** Exactly what you want from a blockbuster. Two bona fide movies stars in Ryan Gosling and Emily Blunt. Solid writing with some character development. Enough laughs (one wishes there were a few more). And some commentary on AI in film. Ryan Gosling is one of the few actors than can expertly blend comedy and drama (Sterling K Brown and Glen Powell can as well), without Gosling the film probably falls a bit short. The writing hints at most of the future developments, detailing them risks spoilers. Hannah Waddingham (*Ted Lasso*) is given a chance to shine in a more comedic role. However none of this should be surprising as the film was directed by David Leitch (*Atomic Blonde*, *Deadpool 2*, and *Bullet Train*) who continues his string of fun action films. The extended version adds twenty minutes without really improving anything (and in a place or two actively makes the film worse)—watch the standard edition. [Critic’s Choice Super Awards – Best Action Movie Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
70. **In A Violent Nature:** An art-house take on the slasher film; Terrance Malick-meets-*Friday the 13th*. The film has the classic tropes: an undead killer stalks a bunch of teens in the woods. However, the film is shot from the killer’s perspective with long-takes, and multiple shots of the killer walking thru the woods. Even at ninety minutes, the film is a tad slow at times. Yet it is the film’s ability to turn the slasher genre on its head, finally bringing something new to an overworked genre, that allows the film to excel. The film is also bolstered by a few great and gory kills. Sadly there isn’t enough extra to move the film higher, but newness is still rewarded. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
69. **The Last Showgirl:** The primary issue with the film is that the run time is already under 90 minutes, and multiple shots are of the main character smoking cigarettes on balconies, the sidewalk, etc; there is a much better film to be made here by expanding out characters and yet it is still padding runtime. Now, it was apparently shot over fourteen days in Vegas, on a two million dollar budget and given those working conditions there is an argument the film could rank higher. Pamela Anderson (*Borat*) is very good in a career-defining role and a role that perhaps only she could play. Brenda Song (*Suite Life*) and Kiernan Shipka (*Totally Killer*) are both good in supporting roles, while unfortunately Jamie Lee Curtis hams it up a bit too much. Dave Bautista (*Knock at the Cabin*) is rather good and one wishes his character got more development. Jason Schwartzman even makes a brief appearance and is hilarious. The film is directed by Gia Coppola so perhaps being Francis Ford Coppola’s granddaughter helps with casting. Had this film delved deeper into its characters it could have been a lot better. [SAG – Best Actress Nominee], *Hulu*.

68. **Hoard:** The debut from writer-director Luna Carmoon, the film is a little long at two hours. The final hour gets a bit repetitive, and a tad too surreal/fantasy (sidenote: what is with indie British films leaning into the fantastical this year?). The set design is great; the title implies the film is about a hoarder, and the sets feel gross-yet-lived-in. Saura Lightfoot-Leon is rather good in her first film role. The film has solid character development and themes, but can't exactly land them in final hour (that once again drags). [British Independent Film – Best Breakthrough Performance Nominee]
67. **Azrael:** A pseudo-silent film that nearly works thanks to Samara Weaving (*Ready or Not*). Weaving, once again is put thru the ringer and gets covered in mud and blood, with only her face to convey emotion and she is able to do the heavy lifting. Although the outline of the plot is good, there are about five faceplam moments of lazy writing that are needed to advance the plot. Depending on how groan-inducing the viewer finds these moments, the film could easily move down a tier. One also wishes the plot was more developed as ideas are half-baked at times (and the film is also constrained by its pseudo-silent approach). Yet both Weaving and some beautiful outdoor camerawork allow the film to be worthwhile. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
66. **Saturday Night:** Few directors are able to deftly handle massive ensemble films; this film has about forty roles, and Jason Reitman (*Up in the Air*) isn't quite up to the task. Likewise, at times one wishes they were watching a documentary about the first episode of *SNL* as artistic license is obviously taken, but given such a large ensemble it is difficult to develop characters. Similarly the script has some laughs, but not enough for it to be a great comedy. Gabriel LaBelle (*The Fabelmans*), Nicholas Braun (*Succession*), Dylan O'Brien (*Love and Monsters*) and Lamorne Morris (*New Girl*) are probably the best cast members, though often times one wishes they were watching the actual cast members (again, a documentary might have been more enjoyable). Also J. K. Simmons nearly steals the show as Milton Berle. It is a solid film that one wishes was executed better. [Golden Globes – Best Actor in a Comedy Nominee], *Netflix*.
65. **The Substance:** The epilogue(? third act?) is awful and nearly ruins the entire film. It should have saved the thirty minutes of runtime and cut it out completely. I could easily move this down a tier or two given how bad it is (while adding almost nothing to the film). Continuing with the flaws, everything involving Dennis Quaid is awful (especially the shrimp eating). The film beats the audience over the head with the various messages and is not subtle about it. Nor is the film campy enough to pull off the obviousness. This is one of those films for normies as it is well-made, while 'challenging' normies at the cineplex. Yet most of the plot comes across as gratuitous and spelling everything out; it needed more mystery. The film does overcome these issues as the visuals, sets, and costumes are rather good (and a few references to various Kubrick films!). The yellow jacket alone is nearly worth a Best Costumes nomination (Dolby Vision does wonders for the film; I highly recommend watching this, or anything really, in Dolby Vision if given the chance). Demi Moore is good, not great (it is a shame she was picked over Pamela Anderson for the aging-star-nomination lane in awards season). Margaret Qualley is amazing as always, The score is also rather good. The film is decent, but the shame is that it could have been great with tweaks or overhauls to the script. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee]
64. **The Apprentice:** A film about Donald Trump (*leading an insurrection*) was always going to be difficult to make. Yet, the first half of the film works. Sebastian Stan (*Fresh*) is very good and is able to even make Trump a sympathetic character in the first half of the film; all while Jeremy Strong (*Succession*) is great as Roy Cohn. Both actors capture their characters insecurities and therefore help the film avoid preaching to the choir. Yet the second-half of the film (once the 80s start) can not deliver as the audience is no longer shown a Trump they've never seen before but rather the same (con-)man we've been dealing with for the last ten-plus years. Nothing new is added to his character and the cinematography goes down hill as well. Hair and makeup is also rather good as the film really does transform Stan into Trump (and Strong into Cohn). [Oscars – Best Actor Nominee]

63. **Queer:** Easily one of the hardest films to rank on the list. The plot is weak, and dragged out (the film is two hours and fifteen minutes, with a lot of filler). Some of the character development is rather weak—especially that of Eugene. Yet, Daniel Craig is amazing in a performance that is reminiscent of his work in *Knives Out*, the lack of an Oscar nomination is sad (again, the script lacks much character development, Craig provides much of it). The sets and miniatures are wonderful. The costumes are good, but there are not many of them. The ayahuasca sequence was rather good and visually impressive. However one’s enjoyment will come down to if they can tolerate the awful plot as the film could easily move down – or up – multiple tiers as the highs are that high, but the lows are that low (much like the lead character’s drug use). [SAG – Best Actor Nominee], *HBOMax*.

Tier 8: Decent but Flawed Wide-Releases and Solid Indies

62. **Before I Change My Mind:** Another 80s-set coming-of-age with an LGBT slant. The production design, on a minimal budget, is rather good. The sets have ‘great’ furniture. The film relies on child actors and gets a fair bit out of them, it would be nice to see if any of them are able to go onto bigger things (sadly it took two years from wrapping to release so the chance to play for kids might be out of reach), especially the lead, Vaughan Murrae. The film makes a big deal about the lead being non-binary (an early shot has them sit with neither the boys nor the girls in the gym) but then does not fully develop that idea. As the film progresses it starts to fall into a few genre traps; especially everything relating to the father’s dating and the not-present mother. For a lesser film, these would tank the production, but the characters are real, and well-acted, even if the plot never fully realizes what could be done with their characters. [GLAAD – Best Limited Release Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
61. **Mountains:** A large chunk of the film is in Spanish, it is about Haitian immigrants after all and the debut of writer-director Monica Sorelle. The star of the film is Atibon Nazaire, whose subtle performance holds the film together. His speech to his son about dreams and hard work is great (though sadly towards the end of the speech there are a few cuts—it does start off uninterrupted). The cinematography is good, with a few shots having excellent framing. And despite the film being about gentrification, the film remains subtle about the process, and avoids being overly preachy (it still should be noted that gentrification is always a result of not building housing where people want to live). This is a compact and solid film about the immigrant experience. [Independent Spirit – Someone to Watch Winner]
60. **Evil Does Not Exist:** Written and directed by Ryusuke Hamaguchi (*Drive My Car*) the film is visually amazing. The nature shots rival those in *Barry Lyndon*. The camera work is some of the best; the camera moves and is then seamlessly attached to the back of a car which then drives away allowing the audience to watch the views behind the car, there is a lengthy tracking shot of people walking through the woods, and swipe cut behind a small bump in the terrain to reveal a second character. There are many more examples of the camera work. The sound design is also impeccable; the sound of leaves and snow under boots, running streams, etc. However the film is poorly written. There is constant foreshadowing such that the viewer knows exactly how the film will end; a little foreshadowing is nice, but almost every bit of dialogue hints at the ending. The film itself is also a little slow, but given the beautiful nature shots, the expertly composed long takes and tracking shots the pace can mainly be forgiven. [Ryusuke Hamaguchi]
59. **Femme:** The film markets itself as a thriller, but that genre is a tad misleading; even if the film is about the main character trying to get revenge. The film excels as delves into the two lead characters and their ever-changing dynamics. And in doing so, the film is able to make the initial perpetrator of a violent and homophobic outburst, sympathetic. And even makes the viewer question the morality of the drag queen who was attacked. By bringing new dynamics to a busy subgenre

(gay-man-gets-attacked-and-the-aftermath) the film is able to excel. George MacKay (*1917*) and Nathan Stewart-Jarrett are both solid as the co-leads. [BIFA – Best Debut Screenwriter Nominee], *Hulu*.

58. **Chicken for Linda! (Linda veut du poulet !):** The painted animation is gorgeous—for the backgrounds. The character design does not do it for me as the lack of definition around the edges becomes distracting, or when characters are in the background they are a paint brush of color with a rough outline. Which is sad as the backgrounds are beautifully simple. The plot itself is a simple tale of overcoming loss and repressed memories. The sequence where the titular Linda realizes what happened, is beautifully done and is the best part of the film. The film ends on a happy note and perhaps more people will find it touching. There are also some jokes, a few land. The plot is a bit zany at times, but in animation that is more forgivable. [Annies – Best Independent Film Nominee]
57. **High Tide:** The film adds some new dynamics to the LGBT film, by focusing on an undocumented immigrant who came to the US to be with his boyfriend, only to be dumped (and the film uses the undocumented character’s lack of awareness of US social customs to makes a few nice statements on race). The film often has many real moments. There are also a few in-you-face scenes about the morality which become grating, and there are about three or four of them. A side-plot feature an artist played by Marisa Tomei isn’t exactly needed, even if it does add a few things to the film. Both leads Marco Pigossi and James Bland are rather good, along with some beautiful seascapes. [GLAAD – Best Limited Release Nominee]
56. **Oddity:** Written and directed by Damian McCarthy (*Caveat*), this is a spooky horror (though perhaps he should find a co-writer). The opening sequence is frightening and sets up the film. The sound design is rather good and helps produce scares. Carolyn Bracken (*You Are Not My Mother*) is rather good in a dual role, and Gwilym Lee (*The Great*) is enjoyable as well. As the various twists and turns begin to be revealed the film does start to lose its luster. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
55. **Late Night with the Devil:** The new approach to both found-footage and deal-with-the-devil horror is what allows the film to excel. David Dastmalchian (*The Suicide Squad*) is the other best thing as his performance as the struggling Late Night host is good; he balances exploitation, genuine shock/concern, and pure likability. The balance is needed to avoid the character becoming one-dimensional (and therefore allowing the audience to be split on his morality). The film itself is not scary and the tension never quite reaches where it should, even if it does slowly ramp up. The ending itself is decent, even if it does not exactly warp everything up. It is interesting enough that the writing-directing duo of Colin and Cameron Cairnes should be watched. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee], *Hulu*.
54. **Longlegs:** A horror (though it is more of a thriller) from Osgood Perkins (*The Blackcoat’s Daughter*) that is one of his better films. It has his hallmark of great (and dark) visuals. The tracking shots, and framing are often great. Maika Monroe (*It Follows* and *Watcher*) is good as always, but not exactly great; partially as the script develops her character a bit but not much. Nic Cage has a supporting role as the titular Longlegs and it allows him to go full ham as only Nic Cage can, and it absolutely works. (Nic Cage’s scenes might be the best part of the movie; Hail Nic Cage!). The suspense doesn’t build as much as one would like, nor are the scares there (again not exactly a horror). [Critic’s Choice Super Awards – Best Horror Nominee], *Hulu*.
53. **Fresh Kills:** A refreshing take on the gangster movie; the film is presented thru the eyes of the mobster’s two daughters. The film is written, directed and stars (in a supporting role) Jennifer Esposito (*Crash*). The sets and costumes are great as they capture the feeling of the late 80s and early 90s. Emily Bader is the breakout star and the moral center of the film (even if the writing of her character is a bit lazy at times). The writing of the film is why it can not rank any higher; there is a major difference between story and screenplay. The general outline of the plot is new and

helps the film rank her. Yet the actual unraveling of the action is weak. The two sisters are direct opposites (a tad lazy). The film jumps forward in time a bit too much (including a lengthy opening prologue and and far too-long epilogue). The epilogue is especially annoying, as it eventually gets to the emotional punch, but it takes fifteen minutes, with one unnecessary speech from a supporting character (a dinner confrontation might be needed but it could have been incorporated better). There is something new and interesting here, one wishes the execution was slightly better. [Well-reviewed Drama], *Hulu*.

52. **Coup de chance:** Written and directed by Woody Allen, albeit for the first time the film is in French (and described as a ‘thriller’ but it really isn’t one). The film has most of Allen’s trademarks including the driving force of the plot being a writer running into his beautiful crush (that he never perused) and the two start a romance (Allen likes to make the same film again and again). The French language might detract from Allen’s usual wit and comedy style. The cinematography by Vittorio Storaro (*Apocalypse Now*) is gorgeous; lots of long takes with the camera moving around characters and such warm lighting that adds to the romantic feeling. The costumes are rather nice, though for a character as rich and spoiled by her husband, one does wonder why some outfits repeat (other than the more practical filming budget restrictions). Lou de Laâge is the star of the film, and gives her character such a realistic effervescence that carries the film, she is a delight and another in a long line of solid performances in the leading role of a Woody Allen film. I will always have a soft spot for Woody Allen’s *films* and although this is not a classic or one of his best, it is nice to see him make one last good film after a string of duds. [Woody Allen], *Peacock*.
51. **Woman of the Hour:** Anna Kendrick’s directorial debut features some nice shots and camera work and a solid performance by her as well. The sets and vibe of the late 70s is well captured. Autumn Best makes a nice film debut. The film is a little in-your-face with the messaging at times, and most of the problems are due to the script. The various time jumps are decent, but they don’t coalesce as well as one would hope. Hopefully Kendrick starts with a stronger script for her second film, as she has shown she has the talent to direct. Unrelated: on dating shows, always pick the Himbo. You actually can’t go wrong with that choice. [Anna Kendrick’s Directorial Debut], *Netflix*.
50. **Heretic:** I love a good minimalist one-location film, but this film can’t exactly keep up with its single-note script. The characters do get some development, but almost all of the development is processed thru the film’s single note: are religions true or a scam? Which, one would imagine, I should be the exact audience for this film, but even I tired of the premise. It was written by the team of Scott Beck and Bryan Woods (*65*), so at least they made up for their previous dud. Hugh Grant (*Paddington 2*) continues to excel when he gets to play the kooky villain. Given there is little action, Grant’s performance is able to elevate the film. It also helps that Chloe East (*The Fabelmans*) and Sophie Thatcher (*Prospect*) are underrated young actresses who are finally getting more starring opportunities. The scares are never really there, but the sets and lighting do provide a near-constant grim and uneasy feeling. [Independent Spirit – Best Screenplay Nominee], *HBOMax*.
49. **In the Summers:** A film that could easily have been cliché, but it instead is able to excel thanks to René Pérez’s performance as the dad. The character goes thru all the expected changes of the deadbeat dad, yet he does them so perfectly that they feel real. Likewise the tiny details are added so nothing feels like a trope; yes he brings his kids to play pool, but he brings his own stick; it isn’t a ‘thing’ to pass time with his kids, but rather one of his hobbies that he genuinely wants to teach kids. The episode approach works given the structure of kids visiting their father on their summer breaks. The various child actors are all good, and help with the development of their characters. It is a well-made film with a great performance and solid characters. It is a solid debut from writer-director Alessandra Lacorazza. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Nominee], *Hulu*.
48. **The Bikeriders:** My primary issue with the film is its structure: it is based on a photo-book about a biker gang in the 60s. The plot then uses the photographer interviewing/being embedded with the

gang as the plot element. This results in interview scenes that do not exactly work, while making the plot choppy. Jodie Comer (*The Last Duel*) is great and carries the film (the interview scenes would be far worse if she was not in them), also her Wisconsin accent is great. That she did not receive any major nominations for her performance is a bit saddening. Austin Butler (*Elvis*) is her love interest, and I am starting to believe Butler's best acting quality is that he is hot. Toby Wallace (*Babyteeth* and *The Royal Hotel*) has a small role one wish was expanded on a bit. As expected Tom Hardy and Michael Shannon are good. If anything the main disappointment is that director Jeff Nichols (*Midnight Special*, *Mud*, *Loving*) didn't make a better film given the cast. It didn't take enough risks and ends up then not being able to explore its characters fully. [Jeff Nichols], *Amazon Prime*.

47. **Mars Express:** A 90-minute animated sci-fi film that tried to cram too many ideas into one plot. Too much happens, with too many characters, for it all to be fleshed out in the brief runtime. Rarely are films accused of being too short, but this is one of those cases. The animation is often solid, and the world-build rather good. There are some twists and turns, only some of which are predictable—but again, at 90 minutes there are too many of them. The various themes of humanity, reliance on technology, tech corporations, personal rights, etc are good however—again there are soo many themes that they all not developed as deeply as they could be. It also does not exactly help that the film borrows a lot from previous science-fiction films. [Annie – Best Independent Film Nominee]
46. **A Complete Unknown:** There are two great items about the film: Timothée Chalamet and Bob Dylan song. Chalamet gives one of the best performances of the year (as to be expected; he's been one of the best actors in the business since he burst onto the scene). While the script itself is mediocre, anytime there is a lull Chalamet performs one of Dylan's greatest songs and the audience is awed by the talent of both artists. Director James Mangold (*Logan*) is good, but the film is not as good as some of his better work. The script fails the character of Sylvie (well-played by Elle Fanning); her relationship with Dylan needed more depth as it serves as the real emotional anchor (not the Dylan-Seeger relationship). Monica Barbaro (*Top Gun: Maverick*) is also good as Joan Baez, but again the script let's down its female characters. Ed Norton is surprisingly good as Pete Seeger. In addition to not developing the character of Sylvie enough, the film does not develop the character of Dylan enough; although those initially mentioned songs were great they eat into (and pad) the runtime, time that could be spent on character development. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Hulu*.
45. **Wicked Part One:** I should preface with that I am not the target audience for this film (or most musicals for that matter; it also does not help that this film has nothing to say about American Monetary Policy!), and I have never seen the original Broadway musical, nor read the book. The best part of the film is Ariana Grande (*Victorious*) and she is amazing in every scene; a perfect casting decision and more than capable of delivering the needed performance (which is a pleasant surprise given how little acting she has done post-Nickelodeon), even if she is a co-lead; not supporting. And not to mention the details on her very pink costumes. Cynthia Erivo (*Harriet*) is also good, but mainly because of her singing ability; the first part does not give her character much room to shine. The biggest issue is that the film could have been much better (and not because they wanted a PG rating). The library set-piece is amazing, and yet director Jon M Chu (*In the Heights*) does almost nothing with it. In the scene watch how quickly the camera cuts; instead of letting the walls spin and actors move above, it constantly cuts (most of the dance numbers feature quick cuts). A scene that had the potential to be an all-timer given the intricate set design, goes almost no where. Likewise the film take the lazy route with background characters; they are all dressed in near-identical costumes (and not give me the BS of 'that is how they do it on Broadway'; this is a film; be cinematic; compare it to the background characters in *Barbie*). The plot itself is a tad too in-your-face (again it has a PG rating and wanted to bring in the cash cows, er, moms and their children, to the theaters). Hopefully Part II takes more artistic chances, but if Grande and Erivo are as good as it will still easily be worth watching. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Peacock*.

44. **The Convert:** A gorgeous film about an early settlement in Australia and the locals interactions with the indigenous people. Now, the viewer can instantly spot where the film is going and what the title actually means (the lead is a preacher; dual meanings!). Guy Pearce (*The Rover*) is good as the lead and provides a rugged moral anchor. The cinematography is excellent (and aided by the natural beauty of the Australian and New Zealand coasts). The ocean shots look amazing, and the framing of shots (Guy Pearce on a stool outside his house is one of the best; another of an overhead shot of a village on a hill with the ship anchored off the beach in the background is excellent). The visuals are that impressive. Lee Tamahori (*Die Another Day*) directs a solid film with good performances, that could have benefited from some less predictable plot points. [AACTA – Best Actor Nominee], *Hulu*.

Tier 7: Good Low-Budget Indies (and Some Others)

43. **Megalopolis:** What is there to say beyond Wow Platinum? Aubrey Plaza (*Emily the Criminal*) is amazing and deserved award recognition. I wanted to think the Globes are still quirky-enough to nominate her for Best Actress in a Comedy, but alas. Part of the negative reviews, are not realizing the film is a comedy. The ‘bad’ lines are funny! Giancarlo Esposito is doing comedy bits! Adam Driver is solid (and always sneakily funny). Shia LeBeouf continues his semi-recent string of underappreciated performances. But the negative reviews are onto something. The film needed to be either ninety minutes longer, or fifty minutes shorter. There are sideplots which are rarely developed, and the plot veers into being non-linear. A long film would allow for those to be flushed out and elaborated (or a shorter films, cuts out all the unnecessary stuff). The effects themselves are often not good. The themes do come together nicely, but can be too heavy-handed. The two issues are that for a film with over a 100-million dollar budget, it should have looked better (the practical effects often look good—the greenscreens not so much). And with the creative control, Coppola should have been able to make the lengthy epic needed to improve the film. For crying out loud, a sequence near the end features three columns of video, reminiscent of the Triptych sequence in Abel Gance’s epic *Napoleon*. *Megalopolis* is no Abel Gance epic – it has its share of flaws – and it could have been much better, but it is still a decent film. [Francis Ford Coppola]
42. **Cabrini:** A biopic that I imagine was partially held back due to the creative team behind the film. The film was directed by Alejandro Monteverde (*Sound of Freedom*) and from the same Angel Studio most known for churning out low-budget Jesus movies. Yet this film is an uplifting portrait of the American immigrant experience. The script has a few flaws, but when the music swells and the voice-overs kick in it becomes difficult not to hope for a better America that welcomes immigrants with open arms. It helps that Cristiana Dell’Anna is rather good as the title character. The cinematography is also rather impressive with multiple shots having excellent framing. While others feature crisp reflections in pianos and water. The film could have been a tad shorter, and toned down some of the obviousness, but it works and it especially works today. [Well-reviewed Drama]
41. **National Anthem:** The debut film from writer-director Luke Gilford about a queer rodeo farm. The film excels in that it shows and never tells. Except in doing so, too many plot elements are underdeveloped and unjustified. Is the character of Dylan genuinely discovering his gender and sexual identities, or partially going along with the flow, or is he merely transfixed with Sky played excellently by Eve Lindley (*Bros*)? As Charlie Plummer is good, but gives a distant performance that comes off like a lesser retread of his excellent and breakout role in *Lean on Pete*. To make matters worse is that this film shares multiple plot elements with *Lean on Pete*. Better character development along with avoiding a few plot cliches and this film could have easily ranked higher as it is beautifully shot with good performances. [Independent Spirit – Best Breakthrough Performance Nominee], *Hulu*.
40. **Didi:** Yet another coming-of-age film. The best parts of this film are that it nails 2008: AIM messages (including messaging SmarterChild when alone and bored), MySpace, and the early use of Facebook.

These period details are great and perhaps given that I grew up in that era, are making me overrate the film out of nostalgia purposes. Now, the issue with the film is that it doesn't exactly explore the depths of its characters. The lead is Tiwanese American, but outside of a few comments on identity (claiming to be half-Asian, and going by Chris), that side is not fully explored. Likewise the skateboarding subplot was done better in *Mid90s*; it also hits a lot of the familiar plot points of the genre; failed crush, making older friends, slipping away from current friends, and family fights. The film actually adds little new to the genre, but it expertly captures the time period and for that it excels. And given that, I actually wonder if writer-director Sean Wang is worth keeping an eye on. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature], *Amazon Prime*.

39. **La Cocina:** Written and directed by Alonso Ruizpalacios, the film is in both English and Spanish. The black-and-white cinematography is absolutely gorgeous; though the film does have a few needless flourishes (the jumpy feel of the opening scene almost takes the viewer out of the movie before it gets going). The plot itself is a tad too predictable (telling a worker he has three strikes, and guess what!) and some unnecessary scenes (feeding the homeless man, the lengthy ending; one can even argue the ending nearly ruins the entire film) could be cut to trim down the over two-hour runtime. A seemingly one-shot scene at the lunch rush is beautiful and possibly the highlight of the film (completely with excellent sound design); another scene in the meat freeze is beautiful. Raúl Briones and Rooney Mara are both great and extend the film beyond beautiful visuals, even if they are part of a large ensemble cast with the various chefs and waitresses in the restaurant. It is not the best film of the year showing the darker side of the immigrant experience, but it is still worth seeking out [Independent Spirit – Best Director Nominee], *Amazon Prime*
38. **Look Back:** The film is only an hour long, and one wishes it was a little longer with more character development (or some supporting characters even). The shortness really limits the ranking a bit. The animation is good, especially the various reflections (there are a few in eyes). Some of the multiple styles work, especially when drawing the manga strips. Yet, the two main characters and their relationship is well-done and carries a lot of emotional weight. It also has a fair bit to say about the cost of success, collaboration, and idolizing your peers. The score is delicate and moving; aiding the emotional impact even more. It is a sweet, short, and moving film. [Annie – Best Independent Film Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
37. **Monolith:** A sorta-horror that can not stick its landing. In fact the ending becomes a retread of recent horror films. The film sets up multiple strands and in the ending can not weave them back together (and again, the attempts to do so end up shameless stealing from other, and better, films). Despite the ending, the film is able to keep up its single-location single-actor premise with tension. Lily Sullivan is up for the challenge of being the only actor on screen; other characters are heard via phone calls and seen in home videos. It still remains one of the few films with genuine tension, and only one-or-two lulls, but most of that is thrown away with a poor ending. As the film gets so much out of a simple and small premise it can still rank here despite not pulling it off. [AACTA – Best Indie Film Nominee], *Peacock*.
36. **Kensuke's Kingdom:** One needs to make it past a few plot contrivances at the start of the film: both(?) parents lost their jobs and they decided to take their kids sailing around the world, and the dog was stowawayed without anyone hearing it, also eventually the kids get lost in the Atlantic Ocean, not the Pacific Ocean, which does not add up. Thankfully, the animation is gorgeous, especially the backgrounds and 'paintings', the film looks wonderful. The environmental themes are good, but a bit forced at times. The score is solid and so is the sound design (the rain storm is well done). [Annie – Best Independent Film Nominee]
35. **We Grown Now:** Written and directed by Minhal Baig, with gorgeous cinematography by Pat Scola (there is a shot where one kid continues up the stairs to his apartment and it looks great and

foreshadows the looming divide between the friends). The film gets excellent performances by its two leading children: Blake Cameron James and Gian Knight Ramirez. The film suffers from some writing issues: particular it falls into a few tropes of the coming-of-age genre (it isn't much of a spoiler, but surprise one of the kids will move away and you can guess how the other one reacts). The writing is a little too on the nose at times; particular the grandmother's speech about leaving Mississippi; the audience could infer why a black family would leave the state for Chicago. Also given that the film develops a child-like nostalgia for the notorious Cabrini-Green (*Candyman*) housing project, one wishes the grandma was a little nostalgic for Mississippi; it would have allowed for that theme to come thru more in the film. The imagination sequences are great (and it puts *Bird* to shame). A few re-writes and this film had the potential to move up a few tiers, but it is still a solid entry into Americana and coming-of-age genres. [Independent Spirit – Best Cinematography Nominee], *Netflix*.

34. **Kneecap:** If I had a nickel for every movie about an obscure UK-based musical act on the list, I'd have two nickels. A fictionalized account of the (Northern) Irish rap group Kneecap, with all three members playing themselves. Michael Fassbender is in the film, but only in a small supporting role (don't get your hopes up if he's the reason you want to see it). The film follows the generic set up of a rap group being formed, and the constable lady is a bit of a cartoon villain. The film primarily succeeds due to is politics surrounding Irish liberation and the use of the Irish language. The second ingredient in the film success is that it does not take itself seriously; some of the subtitles are drawings for example. It is charming, funny, and well-made. [BIFA – Best British Independent Film], *Netflix*.
33. **A Different Man:** If I had a nickel for each film on the list where Sebastian Stan plays a lonely semi-sympathetic character only to turn into an asshole in the second half, I'd have two nickels. It should be noted that Stan is better in this film than *The Apprentice* (the Oscars got their nominations backwards). Though for as good as Stan is, Adam Pearson almost steals the show and the introduction of his character drives the second-half of the film, while offering a great meta-commentary on the plot (and allowing for a more interesting analysis of 'disability'). The plot itself is great – even if it does not stick the landing – with a lot of jokes. The film is a dark comedy, and not realizing that the delivery and dialogue are funny. Renate Reinsve (*The Worst Person in the World*) is also good in her English-language debut. The production design is rather good, as although it is set in the present day (a character is watching a tablet) the sets make everything look like the 70s and 80s (which also adds to the out-of-place theme of the film). Also most of the shots are single takes, which is nice. A more thought out ending would have improved a solid film. [Golden Globes - Best Actor in a Comedy], *HBOMax*.
32. **How to Have Sex:** This film could rank higher if the sound design was good. Far too much of the dialogue is muffled or "whispered" (it also does not help that a few characters have some extreme British accents). Which is sad, as the characters are well-developed, even if the plot could have used a bit more structure (though, perhaps that is because of the poor sound design). Although Tara is the main character, excellently played in a breakout role by Mia McKenna-Bruce, it is the insecure Skye that helps hold the film together and help drive the developments. A meeting with a group of older vacationers is heartbreaking. It is a solid debut from writer-director Molly Manning Walker, though one hopes in the future they get the sound design right. [BIFA – Best Director Nominee], *Netflix*.
31. **My Old Ass:** Written and directed by Megan Park (*The Fallout*; which apparently the DGA considered a TV movie, as it nominated her for Best First Feature). Although the film's advertising leaned on the big name of Aubrey Plaza (*Megalopolis*), she is a small supporting role. The film is Maisy Stella's (her film debut), and she crushes it. The film offers a fresh take on the coming-of-age genre (though the viewer needs to buy into the shroom-induced plot). Detailing what makes it special and unique risks spoilers. Megan Park was directed another solid and touching film. [DGA – Best First Feature Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

30. **Monkey Man:** In my 2023 list, with *John Wick: Chapter 4* along with a few of the film's knock-offs we might have exhausted the new-age action film. *Monkey Man* has destroyed that narrative. The fight scenes (often hand-to-hand combat and some knife-fights) look great and have amazing choreography (perhaps that the film eschews gun fights helps). Some of the fight sequences are traditional boxing scenes and even those look great (in part from a minimalist-yet-gritty ring and audience). The film has a few lovely shots (mirrors in the VIP room), but it does drag at times. I assume I missed a few of the India-specific social commentary and lore, but most can be followed; if anything some of the commentary is a tad too blunt. One to appreciate is that the film had a budget of 10 million dollars. It looks far better than 10 million dollars, and you are amazed Dev Patel was able to make it at that cost. It still isn't anything special, but rather it is a well-made action film. [BAFTA – Best British Debut Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
29. **Hundreds of Beavers:** An instant cult classic and a throwback to the age of silent comedy and Loony Tunes; no real dialogue and in beautiful grainy black and white. The film is not perfect; the almost hour-and-fifty runtime is a bit much, and the first twenty minutes is a bit rough. However, the gags set up in the beginning do come back and payoff later in the film. Most of the gags are inventive and funny. The film makes great use of the low-budget; the animal costumes are hilarious and the horse might be the best part. For a budget of 150k it is difficult to make a better film. It isn't perfect, but it is fun. And if you don't find it fun, have a few more adult beverages (preferably Applejack) and give it another try. [Well-reviewed Comedy], *Amazon Prime*.
28. **Flow:** An independent animated film, created using a free and open-source animation software (I imagine the use of this software has helped buoy critical reviews; technically anyone could have made this film). At times the animation does look iffy (the cat jumping, the golden retriever doing things, the dogs panting, etc), but for a budget of 3.5 million euros, it looks very good (but not great). The animals to look, act, and sound, like animals; there is no anthropomorphizing here, nor any dialogue. Part of the charm is animals acting like animals is cute. The plot is okay (and basic) the cat overcomes its fears and learns to socialize. The film could have ranked a tier higher if it pulled its plot together. It tries a few things that never quite payoff nor does the plot turn into any noticeable allegory. Not that plots need to, but what you are mainly left with are cute animals doing cute animal things. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Winner], *HBOMax*.
27. **Blitz:** Written and directed by Steve McQueen (*12 Years A Slave* and *Shame*) this is easily his worst film. That isn't much of an insult given the quality of his four previous films. But when he does make a film, you wish it was better given his talent. The film doesn't have his usual lengthy tracking shots (there is one in a night club, but it adds little) or long-takes for dialogue. Thankfully the (few) scenes of the actual bombing, and for once the viewer wishes there was more pointless action as the nighttime bombings looked and sounded great. The dual plot of the film is a bit haphazard as the child's plot is rather episodic, whereas the mother's plot (played by Saoirse Ronan) never figures out its politics. Though I do admit, I probably missed multiple British-isms. The effects are often good, the sets and costumes are often good. Hans Zimmer's score is good. It is well made, but one wishes McQueen made a better film. [BAFTA – Best British Film Nominee], *AppleTV+*.
26. **Janet Planet:** Written and directed by Annie Baker in her film debut. The cinematography by Maria von Hausswolf (who has primarily shot Danish films before this one) is gorgeous; so many shots are brilliantly composed and framed. The film itself is rather slow and often lacking on narrative, but the cinematography really carries the film thru what would normally be lulls and slogs. It is also one that could look better in the future when revisited as although the film is slow there is a lot of subtle character development that can easily be missed. Julianne Nicholson (*Dream Scenario*) is rather good, but the real find is Zoe Ziegler who plays the daughter and who's coming of age the film revolves around. Yet, despite the subtle character development, one wishes more happened as the

film is an hours and fifty minutes. It isn't that slow, but for the length one wishes more was packed in. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Nominee], *HBOMax*.

25. **Exhibiting Forgiveness:** Written and directed by Titus Kaphar in his directorial debut. Kaphar is a painter, and the film makes great use of his own paintings (one could even say his paintings are the best part of the film, and that would not be a knock on the film; also the use/creation of the paintings are the best cinematic parts). André Holland (*Moonlight, Shirley*) and John Earl Jelks are both rather good as the leading son and the support father (in need of forgiveness); their scenes together are great. The film itself leans into religious aspects too much. However, the characters are well developed and as an artist Kaphar has an eye for framing the shots. The character development (and flashbacks) help guide the film thru any rough patches. [Black Reel – Outstanding Film Nominee], *Hulu*.
24. **Nosferatu:** This film should by most all standards rank a tier (or two) higher. The low-light cinematography is amazing. The framing of shots is picturesque; with a narrow aspect ratio, and frequently position characters in the center of the frame. Jarin Blaschke continues his excellent work being Egger's cinematographer. The sets are costumes are bleak but gorgeous. The cast is good, but one does not watch for the acting; it is the visuals that carry the film. The film is also far more sexual than one would expect from a Gothic horror. And yet for all the good in the film, I can not rank it higher. I am a fan of *Nosferatu (1922)*, and this remake does not add much. The only main change is giving more inspiration for why Nosferatu does what he does; but I do not need much character development for an evil vampire. Being an evil vampire is enough to get buy-in as an audience member. The film also provides more character development for Ellen, but the new development does not add much and is often muddled; she is semi-responsible for bringing the vampire to the town, but also knows she has save the town. The film never figures out what specific themes it wanted to shine thru with the focus on her character development. Eggers remade an all-time classic, while adding little new to the plot. Which then comes down to why one of the current great directors did not make something new. Few directors are as good, have as much creative control, and have access to large budgets (the film cost about 50 million). It is a shame we got an unnecessary, but gorgeous remake; instead of a new, original, and I feel safe saying equally gorgeous movie. [Oscars – Best Cinematography Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

Tier 6: Really Good Dramas

23. **The Piano Lesson:** Adapting an August Wilson play (*Fences, Ma Rainey's Black Bottom*) is a recipe for success. Admittedly one does wonder how much of the screenplay is new vs lifted from the play. The sets and costumes (and all of the production design) elements are good. This play might be the best of the three films so far in terms of source material (the other two adaptations had Viola Davis). Malcolm Washington (son of Denzel) does a good job in his directorial debut, and one never feels that the film is a stage play; the climax is especially well done. John David Washington (son of Denzel) overacts a little bit and often hams it up. Ray Fisher and Danielle Deadwyler are the two best actors. Denzel Washington plans on producing more August Wilson plays and if the trend continues we are in store for seven more great films. [SAG – Best Supporting Actress Nominee], *Netflix*.
22. **Juror #2:** Clint Eastwood, despite his age, continues to direct well-made films. There are not many directorial flourishes, yet all the shots are well-composed and the editing is solid. The script has lots of various themes on justice, policing, and politicization of the district attorney's offices. Nicholas Hoult (*The Great*) is good not great in the leading role and was expertly cast as the role has a bit of his trademark style, but a bit more dramatic (even if Warner Brothers did not botch the film's rollout I doubt he would have received much in the same of nominations). The same can be said about Toni Collette (*Hereditary*), who at times slips into an off-kilter southern accent. It also does not help that

the film does not fit nicely into any one political narrative, without all sides being grilled for their faults. It is well-made and found new things to add to the crowded courtroom genre, but one wishes it had a bit more to allow the film to reach the higher tiers. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film], *HBOMax*.

21. **Ghostlight:** The second film from the (married) team of Kelly O’Sullivan and Alex Thompson (*Saint Frances*). Like their first film (both written by O’Sullivan), it does a great job of combining comedy with serious drama; there a multiple laugh-out-loud moments, and a few subtle dark comedy bits. Keith Kupferer (*Princess Cyd*) is rather good and is able to guide the film through some lulls (which there are a few; in particular the deposition scenes are a little long); the potentially convenient plot points and developments never bothered me and I thought worked but perhaps some might find them a little too convenient. Kupferer’s real-life daughter Katherine Mallen Kupferer plays in in-film daughter and absolutely steals the show as the angry-and-agnsty theater kid. The entire ensemble is enjoyable and helps bring a lot of laughs. For O’Sullivan’s second film she has established herself as a someone who can weave comedy into emotional dramas that although they get close to being sappy but never quite do as they are grounded in well-developed characters. Perhaps my only knock is that the film uses *Under Pressure* and after watching *Aftersun* the song only reminds me of *Aftersun* and although the song absolutely ruined me mid-movie it is because of a different movie. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film], *Hulu*.

20. **Challengers:** As an avid tennis fan, some of my review is the details are great, but at other times it doesn’t take the tennis seriously enough. The details of the grind and day-to-day life of tennis players, the various events, the changes in major sponsors over time are spot on. But the in-game is not. When a prevailing theme is the pure emotion of playing tennis, as a tennis lover, I wanted more realism; playing angles, attacking the right ball, etc. Instead the film shows in-game tennis with little movement, extremely long points, and always hitting 100 percent. Too often the tennis ball has been done via VFX. There are some good cinematic flourishes (shooting the action from ‘underneath’ the court looking up), though not all work for me (at one point the camera functions as the tennis ball). The score is interesting, some people will probably get into it, but it was far too industrial for my tastes. Thankfully the three leads are all near perfect (and the make up department did a great job de-aging them as the movie takes place over the course of 13 years). We’ve known for year that Zendaya is extremely talented and this is yet another showcase for her skill. Josh O’Connor (*Emma.*) is the proper level of grimy and charming and effortlessly moves between the two. Mike Faist (*West Side Story*) is wonderful as well. Enjoy the great acting, the interesting visuals, and the sexual tension. Ignore the some of the tennis. [Critic’s Choice – Best Editing], *Amazon Prime*.

19. **Rebel Ridge:** Written and directed by Jeremy Saulnier (*Green Room*), the film turns the revenge thriller/action movie on its heels (and depending on how much the viewer buys into the action, it could even move up a tier). The police are the unabashed bad guys (include solid performances by Don Johnson and Emory Cohen (*The Bikeriders*)). Even at two-hours-ten-minutes long, the film never drags as it slowly, methodically, and logically builds suspense and weaves its tangled web of cops-being-evil. Aaron Pierre (*Brother*) solidifies himself as a move star as his laid-back, yet calculating demeanor is needed to give the film time to weave the web (the audience never wants to slow play the revenge, and without Pierre being stoic, the audience would question why the character wants to be so methodical). Likewise AnnaSophia Robb shows she has graduated from her child and teen roles to an adult actor with acting chops. Though some viewers might want more in-your-face action, it is the build-up and complete evisceration of modern policing that carries the film. [Critic’s Choice – Best TV Movie], *Rebel Ridge*.

18. **Memoir of a Snail:** A stop-motion R-rated animated film from writer-director Adam Elliot (*Mary and Max*). The script is a tad repetitive at times, so at 95-minutes it isn’t perfect. However the script mixes pathos and (adult) comedy perfectly and therefore overcomes any plot issues (as the

title suggests, there isn't a 'plot', but rather the main character recounting their life). But seriously, some of the jokes are great (and a wide-range of joke types) and are often in the middle of a heart-wrenching portion. This delicate balance is achieved because Sarah Snook (*Succession*) is amazing; that she was not even nominated for Voice Acting at the Annies is a travesty. She delivered the best voice acting performance of the year. Replacing Snook with a different actress and this film most certainly moves down a tier, perhaps more if the film no longer achieves its balance. The animation style is good and unique and adds to the odd-ball charm of the film. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Nominee]

17. **I'm Still Here (Ainda Estou Aqui):** The film is Fernanda Torres' film. She is very good in the film (and probably the best out of the Best Actress *Nominees*). Her restraint and desire to keep the family together and shield the kids from pain and anguish is great. The production values are rather good as well; the film recreates 1970s Brasil. The film is about the then-dictatorship taking political prisoners so some American viewers might like that connection to today. There are a few redundant scenes, for example one daughter wearing her dad's shirt. Yet the film features two epilogues that are both too long. Only one is needed and it could have been shorter (as one is needed to drive home the impact). Given the film is two-hours-and-fifteen minutes long, these are not needed. Had the ending(s) been better this would move up a tier. [Oscars – Best Actress Nominee], *Netflix*.

Tier 5: Almost Must Watch

16. **Girls Will Be Girls:** Written and directed by Shuchi Talati, in what I believe is her first feature film. There might be a few lines in Hindi (unfortunately I could not find forced subtitles, but even lines I misheard were in English, but due to accents). The film is a realistic coming-of-age tale. I might not know that much about the Indian culture that are in the film, but enough is implied and the deeper cuts would only enhance someone's enjoyment; along with a fair bit of universal social commentary. The heart of the film is a daughter meeting a boy, and both of their relationships with her mother. Most all of his motivations are slowly, and authentically revealed over the two-hour runtime. Given the characters are so organic, the film never bogs down these are real people living their lives. Both actresses – Preeti Panigrahi and Kani Kusruti – are great and both deserved some award recognition. The cinematography is rather good, there are some great framed (and often in deep focus) shots of the characters in their home. [Independent Spirit – John Cassavetes Award]
15. **Dune: Part Two:** I could almost bring up my review for the first film. It still looks great, it still lacks character development, and the plot is still uneven (some points are dragged out, others wrap up far too quickly). Yet the second time around, it is now as impressive; the excellent sound design became old hat, the costumes are now hand-me-downs, the luscious sandscapes have been seen before. I did not need six hours of gorgeous desert vistas; the first three in the first film were enough. Now the scenes on the Harkonnen planet do look good in their nearly black-and-white visuals (We will ignore Austin Butler doing another bad accent). The IMAX screening looked good, and helped the spectacle a bit, but it was not a must-see event. Rebecca Ferguson is probably the best (partially because she has the most developed character; too often the movie supplements development with sheer star power). There will most likely be a third installment, and although it will be worth watching, the anticipation is gone. Hopefully it will be set on a different planet. As Denis Villeneuve has taken the Arrakis and, uh, mined it for all it is worth. [Oscars – Best Sound], *HBOMax*.
14. **Civil War:** The film has some flaws. The most evident is the amount of exposition in the dialogue (when the Civil War is not based in reality, and the characters are made up, it does require some explaining. But too often characters tell the audience their back-story). Kirsten Dunst (*Melancholia*) is good, but nothing special. The same can be said about Cailee Spaeny (*Priscilla*). Instead of fully developing either character, the film is more interested in grand thematic statements about the role

of the media (which for the most part the film does land said statements). The film deserves a Best Sound Nomination; the entire battle of DC sequence is amazing. Although the sound is near perfect, one wishes the visuals were a tad better (production constraints meant few long takes during battle) and more handheld/free-moving camera work doesn't exactly do it for me. The critic's who didn't like an even bleaker future of America (given it is 2024) are wrong and should be ignored. The critic's who didn't like the lack of backstory on the Civil War are wrong and should be ignored. It is still an improvement over *Men* for Alex Garland, but inferior to his instant-classics *Ex Machina* and *Annihilation*. [ACE – Best Editing Drama Nominee], *HBOMax*.

13. **The Fire Inside:** Few films were done as dirty as this one as it was released the same weekend as *Nosferatu*, *Babygirl*, and *A Complete Unknown*. Given the start power of those films, this one was going to have a hard time breaking through. Barry Jenkin's (*Moonlight*) script is rather good: characters speak naturally, the character development is shown not told, and features multiple little arcs. The film cinematographer-turned-director by Rachel Morrison features solid boxing choreography, as well as some well-lit shots. The film is able to bring something unique to the rags-to-riches sports film, by focusing on what happens after the initial success and the achievement of the primary goal. Ryan Destiny has a breakthrough performance while Brian Tyree Henry continues to show why he is one of the best actors in the business today. This should have been a bigger awards contender, but never was able to get the recognition as it was overshadowed during its release weekend. [Independent Spirit – Best Cinematography Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
12. **A Real Pain:** Written and directed by Jessie Eisenberg; his second film in both of those roles. His direction is solid, with a mobile camera that follows actors around (it often circles around). His script has lots of witty, comedic, and heart-felt dialogue (he incorrectly state that one could get a train from Penn Station to Binghamton, NY. In reality one would go to Port Authority and get a bus. Yet this sin can be forgiven). The script is a tight 90 minutes with little to no fluff. Kieran Culkin is the best part of the film (and is the co-lead; his nominations are a horrendous case of category fraud). Yet he plays a similar to his one in *Succession*, and one has to partially wonder if he keeps playing versions of himself. But he is that good, and a different actor probably could not carry the film as the role requires a delicate balance of great guy and an asshole. The film is set up on needing to feel the right amount of sorry for his character, while also realizing there might not be any helping him. Culkin nails it. [Oscars – Best Supporting Actor], *Hulu*.
11. **September 5:** Paramount had two of the better films this year, and completely botched the release. This film had its release date pushed back multiple times (some theaters across the country even canceled showings) while most showing came with a cast Q&A (that may have been before the screening(!) at some theaters). For full disclosure, my showing started exactly at the listed started time (wtf AMC?) so I missed the first three minutes before the title card (don't worry, I went home and, uh, found a way to watch it). I also hope the film wasn't shunned for showing a situation where Israeli people were killed by Palestinians, as if so that is more evidence the 'Watermelon Emoji People' are the absolute worst. Onto the film itself: it is a tight 95 minutes. The script and editing keep the action moving; condensing twenty-two hours of real-time action. Peter Sarsgaard (*Memory*) is rather good, while John Magaro (*Past Lives* and *LaRoy, Texas*) is the breakout star as the young producer. The film is also able to get at the ethics of journalism, while doing so in an analog film (multiple sequences are trying to find real-time solutions in an analog world). The set design is rather good, as the viewer is immersed in a 1972-production studio (it is also where almost all of the film is shot; the cramped location adds to the tension). Oh and the film even got Leonie Benesch (*The Teacher's Lounge*) in a crucial supporting role both for the plot and added meaning. This is a tight and trilling film with great production values and solid performances. [Oscars – Best Original Screenplay Nominee], *Paramount+*.
10. **Nickel Boys:** Let's get the discussion of the POV camera-work out of the way first: at times is

really works; allowing for a literal change of view, a few times a scene is shot from both character's viewpoint (it could have done this on one or two more occasions); the shots where you then see the main character reflected look amazing. Yet the format is also limiting and given the film's two-hour-and-twenty-minute runtime the film bogs down a lot (the entire starting sequence is a bit of a chore). And so when the film slows down, and is also constrained by the camera the slow parts get very slow. Likewise the score is good, but is not used enough. Camerawork and scores can carry films thru their lulls (very little happens in both *2001* and *TGTBTU*). The plot is a tad episodic at time but most of the episodes come back to be meaningful at the end, but they are also so slow that the viewer misses some of them at the end of the film. Had the film cut out a few sequences (the space race stuff and the lengthy opening), it would easily rank higher. And it is probably the film on the list that most requires a rewatch to fully appreciate the film. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

9. **Conclave:** Edward Berger's (*All Quiet on the Western Front*) first (primarily) English-language film. It has his usual hallmarks of quality production values and set pieces. A large chunk of the rating is that the viewer does believe this is the Vatican; an impressive feat. And again Volker Bertelmann provides a banging score (but not as good as *Western Front*). Just about everyone in the cast does a great job: Ralph Fiennes, Stanley Tucci, John Lithgow, and Isabella Rossellini. One does wonder how much of the quality is a result of the source novel and that the main advantage here is the production values and acting quality. As one does find it a little shocking to become so invested in the search for a new pope. Detailing the various twists and turns risks spoilers, but they all generally work (but again that is a source material benefit). One can also imprint their views about current politics onto the film as well, which can help viewers enjoyment. It is technically well-made, with great performances, but it lacks that something extra to elevate it into higher tiers. [Oscars – Best Adapted Screenplay], *Amazon Prime*.

Tier 4: The Best of the Best Picture Contenders

8. **The Brutalist:** I was able to see the film in 70mm (the film was shot in 35mm VistaVision, so 70mm is a suitable format) so some of the review might be a bit biased in how 'natural' the film looked at times, given it was actually show on film and not (crisp) digital. Including the fifteen minute intermission, the film runs over three hours and thirty minutes. Yet, it never feels slow. The issue is the that the first half of the film sets up multiple themes, but the second half can not bring them all home. Most of the issues the film sets up also manage to capture the zeitgeist of today's America; immigration, wealth inequality, anti-semitism, heroin use. But for an epic film about the seedy-underbelly of American life the film is only ever good, not great. It never reaches the lofty heights it aspires to. Which is sad, as some of the shots are gorgeous: the train derailment, the Italian mine, the shots of city skylines. The score is all over the place—in a good way; it is lyrical at times and industrial in others. Adrian Brody (*The French Dispatch*) is amazing and he needs needs to as the camera often lingers (a lot of the takes are rather long, requiring the actors to be dialed in; perhaps because of shooting in VistaVision, to keep costs down it was difficult to use multiple cameras and multiple takes). Guy Pearce (*The Convert*) gives possibly the best performance in the film as the wealthy, and self-indulgent, patron; the character frequently and suddenly changes tone and Pearce is able to pull it all off. I can't believe I am saying it, but Joe Alwyn (*reputation* and *Lover*) is great as the cocky and arrogant son. The character is one-dimensional, but Alwyn pulls it off. Director Brady Cobert (*Childhood of a Leader*) continues to make visually beautiful films on smaller budgets, but he has trouble pulling of the finishes. This film never fully lets you down in the second half; you know that it could have been an all-time film as it desperately want to be great, but it ends up being only very good. [Oscars – Best Actor], *HBOMax*.
7. **Anora:** I watched this film before awards, while it was receiving a lot of Oscar buzz. I can't say the buzz is warranted as the film is rather good, but not great. However, Sean Baker (*Starlet*, *Tangerine*,

The Florida Project, and *Red Rocket*) has been making films that frequently land in my top-fifteen, that he is in line for an Oscar (either for his writing or directing). The writing in particular is great, as the film is a throwback to the old-school screwball comedies (sadly it took the audience at my showing to realize the film was a comedy; might have detracted a little from my enjoyment). The soon-to-be-famous ‘home invasion’ scene is a twenty-five minute tour de force that is hilarious and exhilarating—yes, it keeps it up for all twenty-five minutes. Mikey Madison (*Once Upon a Time in Hollywood*) is rather good, but her performance did not stand out as a sure-fire Best Actress winner (or even nominee?). Her titular character of Anora is well developed, and the film’s ending does an excellent job of tying everything together about love, attraction, and intimacy (but further details would risk spoilers). The film is rather good, but not deserving of its Oscar front-runner status. [Oscars – Best Picture], *Hulu*.

Tier 3: Must Watch

6. **The Wild Robot:** A gorgeous and moving animated film. The colors are amazing; especially the skies and the sunsets. The fires also look amazing, and so does the snow; so many of the things that are difficult to animate the film does perfectly. Anything dealing with light (from the sun) looks amazing; the shadows cast and how only part of the woodland animals are illuminated. Said woodland animals look adorable as well. As the titular robot collects moss and dings and dents these are expertly detailed on the robot. The animation quality is truly top notch. The voice cast is excellent as well with Lupita Nyong’o most likely giving the voice performance of the year, though Pedro Pascal is great as well. Kit Connor rounds out the primary voice and is good. All of these words and still not anything about the tear-jerking plot. Now admittedly, one can roughly guess where the plot will go, but the individual moments along the way are all perfect, making any predictability concerns fly away. The film is technically excellent with good characters, great voice acting, and a plot the entire family can enjoy. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
5. **Babygirl:** Nicole Kidman continues to be excellent and take on amazing roles (*Lion*, *Killing of the Sacred Deer*, *Boy Erased* and others). She is absolutely amazing and puts in one of the best performances of the year. Harris Dickinson (*The Iron Claw* and *Scraper*) is decent, but can’t fully match Kidman in the various scenes (which is mainly a comment on how good Kidman is). Halina Reijn (*Bodies, Bodies, Bodies*) writes and directs (she only directed *Bodies*). Her script is great with multiple callbacks; two scenes in hotel (one cheap and one swanky), two late-night hot tub encounters, and one other that I won’t spoil. The long take in the cheap hotel is one of the best scenes of the year. The film excels with the development of all of its characters. The film is not *50 Shades*-with-Kidman, it has complex characters who explore their sexuality and all dimensions of it. Then of course the added layers of office politics and culture, with detailed family dynamics as well. The depth of the characters elevates the film beyond an outstanding Kidman performance. [National Board of Review – Best Actress], *HBOMax*.
4. **Hit Man:** Richard Linklater (*School of Rock*) has a unique skill where he can direct innovative all-time greats, while also crafting near-perfect everyday movies. *Hit Man* is a near perfect everyday movie. Glen Powell (*Twisters*) is amazing in a dual-ish role of the timid Gary and the macho Ron (and a few other ‘characters’). Powell deserved more award recognition for his acting. Powell also co-wrote the screenplay with Linklater and the script is tight and hilarious, as right when the film is starting to get repetitive, Adria Arjona (*Andor*) shows up. Her chemistry with Powell is electric. The ‘Apple Notes’ scene is one of the best of the year. Austin Amelio is enjoyable in a supporting role. The film isn’t that deep, but it has enough philosophical discussions (literally) that when put together with the acting and jokes makes for a grand fun time. [WGA – Best Adapted Screenplay Nominee], *Netflix*.

3. **Sing Sing:** The film that is perhaps most overlooked during this years awards season. The film rightly deserved its Best Actor and Best Adapted Screenplay nominations. Yet it was scarcely nominated for Best Support Actor; Clarence Maclin is better than Colman Domingo, for the first hour of the film; the last forty minutes Domingo's character is given a few scene stealing opportunities (Clemency Hearing, and Dress Rehearsal, among a few others) and Domingo crushes them as to be expected. Domingo is one of the best actors in the business now, and is due for an Oscar. The ensemble of fellow prisonmates-turned-actors is great, and this is the category where the lack of nominations is the biggest disappointment as they all did great and without their skillful performances, the film would not have the emotional weight it did. Part of the emotional impact comes from a quietly excellent score by Bryce Dessner, and the gorgeous on-location 16mm cinematography from Pat Scola (*Pig, Monsters and Men, We Grown Now, A Quiet Place: Day One*). The shots are well framed, and the camera lingers on faces allow the actors to convey all sorts of emotion. It is all tied together by an excellent script (co-written by Director Greg Kwedar) that features multiple callbacks (feather vs brick, and beloved). A film that could have been straight-forward feel-good rehabilitation film, or a generic prison-reform film ends up being an excellent character study that packs an emotional weight while still touching on social issues. [SAG – Best Actor Nominee], *HBOMax*.

Tier 2: Not a True Number One

2. **I Saw the TV Glow:** Written and directed by Jane Schoenbrun (*We're All Going to the World's Fair*; a tiny low-budget film I had in my Top Ten for 2022—a ranking that will continue to look great as Schoenbrun makes more great films). The film is gorgeously composed with beautiful shots and colors; the purple/pink main color looks gorgeous and saturates a few lovely shots. The blues look great as well (and there is a reason they are blue and pink). The nostalgia of the film is very good, and nails the feeling of the early-to-mid 90s. The end of the second act is one of the best sequences of the year and leaves the audience stunned. Sadly it becomes hard to top that, and the third act and epilogue seem a bit dull in comparison, but they still work. Schoenbrun manages to deconstruct and rearrange the coming-of-age LGBT film is a brilliantly bizarre horror-adjacent film. Justice Smith puts in his best performance to date (that he convincingly plays a kid of 13 while being 28 does not crack the top five best parts of his performance). Brigitte Lundy-Paine was also good, but the film is Smith's when it comes to acting. One wishes the film left a few plot points more...opaque. Yet Schoenbrun is on the cusp of becoming the best horror director going. [Independent Spirit – Best Feature Nominee], *HBOMax*.

Tier 1: Monkey Make Me Cry

1. **Better Man:** I. I can not believe I am ranking a movie about a British singer whom I knew nothing about (and never even heard of!) going into the film. Oh, and the singer is a CGI monkey. Maybe the low expectations played a role, but I knew the reviews were good and it had some awards buzz. This is the best musical biopic I've ever seen and one of the best biopics of famous people ever. This film is the e-equals-m-c-squared of musical biopics; it has split the atom and reinvented the genre. It will be the film future biopics are judged against. Most musicals hope for one, maybe two show-stopping numbers. Yet this film has at least *five* show stoppers, in part because the musical numbers are not standard concert or recording numbers. The numbers advance the plot and add layers of characterization. The first show-stopper is "Rock DJ". It is an elaborate and extravagant dance number with the camera moving seamlessly between shops and Regent Street(1) in London. It has pelvic thrusts in the faces of old ladies on scooters. It has gumballs. The camera movement is seamless. It ends with five hundred dancers in the street, no CGI (sans the monkey). It is audacious filmmaking from director Michael Gracey (*The Greatest Showman*) and in the span of a few minutes the film has expertly conveyed Take That's overnight rise to superstardom. The next

show stopper is “She’s the One”, what starts off with a beautiful dance number with Raechelle Banno (who is amazing in her limited screen time), starts to flashforward to their relationship and is able to encapsulate their relationship in a few minutes (again, these songs, all exist to advance the plot organically). The editing of this film is top-notch. Your jaw is on the floor after “She’s the One” and then again quickly during the “Angels” number which expertly cuts to-and-from performances, drug taking, and a funeral. Discussing the “Let Me Entertain You” number risks spoilers, but I can say it is the most audacious musical number in decades, and serves as the climax of the film where (as one would assume) all of the singer’s past problems with drug abuse and mental health come to roost. Yet this standard of every famous person biopic, is done in such a way (that has been set up throughout the entire film) that fully captures the collapse (while a song plays) and does so in a few brisk minutes. Everything a biopic is suppose to do, it finds a way to still do, but in such innovative ways. The film ends with “My Way” and a CGI monkey will bring the audience to tears. Those are the five show-stoppers. Five of them. After 450 words, it is time to directly address the monkey. The monkey not only works, but adds to the film. Partially it allows for the film to bypass one of the more annoying parts of a biopic: making sure the lead looks like person. Secondly, the film is cheeky (the real-life Robbie Williams is a wanker) and having a CGI monkey makes every ‘twat’ that much funnier. Third, it allows some scenes to straddle the line between fantasy and reality; are these dream sequences, a visual illustration of drug dependency; they all work easier when you’ve bought into a CGI monkey. Fourth, it allows Robbie Williams to provide the vocals, while Jonno Davies does the motion capture and dialogue. Fifth, and lastly, a line at the end in rehab brings it all home. This is one of the most original films in years. Don’t be deterred by not knowing who Robbie Williams is. Don’t be mislead into thinking the CGI monkey means the film is a gimmick. The film is a masterpiece of the biopic genre. And when the dust settles in a few years, and we forget that it flopped at the box office, hopefully people look back and realize this film redefined a genre. [Oscars – Best VFX Nominee], *Paramount+*.